The Only Way

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/34019266.

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Not Rated

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Major Character Death

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra)

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Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra)

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Angst with a Happy Ending, Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Catra & Glimmer Friendship (She-Ra), or at least they'll be friends eventually, Canon Divergence, they make a horde friend, Sort Of, Time Travel, Portals, Angst and Hurt/Comfort, Adora Has Issues (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra) Needs a Hug

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by Tadd_the_Turtle

Summary

Light Hope needed She-Ra and her sword to activate the Heart of Etheria.

Adora wasn't going to let her have either.

Glimmer and Catra are imprisoned on Horde Prime's ship. A mysterious Horde soldier is helping them. The rebellion is weak, desperate to get their queen back. And worst of all, the rebellion doesn't know how it's meant to survive when their hero, their savior, their friend...is dead?

Stars (Prologue)

Chapter Summary

a sacrifice made, a martyr born, a hero lost

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Power.

Power coursed through every bone in She-Ra's body, filled the empty spaces in between her atoms, ingrained itself in every molecule.

Pure pain. Nerves on fire. Heart pounding, ready to burst like the heart of the planet. Everything Adora had left to give was channeled into keeping the sword to the ground. She couldn't fire the weapon. She couldn't.

"You will comply." Light Hope urged her to keep going, using Adora as she always had. The poor girl gripped onto the sword as every instinct in her body fought against itself. *Fire it. Stop it. Fire it. Stop it.*

Adora could feel the princesses weakening. They were connected after all. They were in pain, and to make matters worse, she could feel everything they could. Agonizingly, Adora fought to stay focused knowing if she succumbed to the misery for even a moment...it would all be over.

With every bit that she pushed the sword down, it just felt like it floated higher. The magic flowing through Adora couldn't be contained much longer. She knew better than most that she couldn't keep this up forever. On top of that, no one else was coming. This was a fight she'd have to face alone.

"This isn't my destiny," Adora spat the words out. "I am not your weapon." She managed a look at Light Hope to see the aged hologram faltering. Regardless, both knew there was no fighting her programming, just like there was no fighting Adora's.

"Mara knew you were more than this," Adora pleaded in a last ditch effort. If she could just get herself a little more time, get Light Hope to loosen for just one moment...

It was working. Light Hope was glitching, caught between two different selves. Adora could feel the conflict waging inside her as the sword lifted even more forcefully than before.

Light Hope seemed to make up her mind.

"Do it."

Oddly enough, this part didn't take as much effort as she thought, or maybe it just seemed that way. In the brief moment before the sword hit, Adora felt something she hadn't expected: clarity. This moment was the moment she knew had been coming from the start, the moment she'd dreaded, and yet, in that moment...everything fell into place.

Braced for the inevitable, Adora used what was left of her strength to plunge the sword downwards. Shattering, Adora sucked in a breath as the shrapnel lodged itself into her torso.

The Crystal Castle was reduced to rubble before her very eyes. Adora barely made out the image of Light Hope standing above her, thanking her, before the woman disappeared. The whole cavern seemed to erase itself from existence. As she was left standing there, she looked around. She was alone and bleeding in a void of nothing.

Coughing, Adora was lying on the floor now. She didn't remember getting there. She could feel the metal pushing against her insides with every breath. Biting her tongue, Adora pulled a larger chunk of metal out — the hilt —splattering even more blood onto the floor. Gasping in pain, she knew all too well she was only making

the process go quicker. Thinking of her friends now, it seemed better to go quick instead of giving them hope. The thought of them blaming themselves when this went south? No, they'd be better off if they didn't try to save her. No more She-Ra meant no more pawn to be played. If there was any comfort to this, it came from the shock that was taking over, numbing the pain if only slightly.

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Footsteps. Shouting. The figure lying on the ground didn't get up to see who it was. They didn't have to, as Bow came into eye shot moments later. He could barely see through the tears in his eyes but then again, maybe he didn't want to see this. Cursing, he scooped Adora up, stumbling to the exit and dodging debris.

"Did it work?" Adora asked.

Choking on his own tears Bow nodded. He could feel her getting weaker in his arms. "Yeah...it-it did."

Adora smiled. Bow couldn't believe it. How could she smile at a time like this? If this was the price they had to pay, it wasn't worth it.

They were outside. Bow ran but he didn't seem to know where to. Adora looked from him to the sky above her.

"Stars," Adora muttered. "I missed seeing...the stars..."

Bow looked down at her. Overwhelmed and hopeless, Bow stopped in his tracks. There was nowhere to go. The color had drained almost completely from Adora's skin and she could hardly keep her eyes open.

"No..." he whispered. "Not like this. Please."

Adora's pulse was getting fainter. By the looks of it, she didn't have any fight left in her. "It's ok." Her voice shook, maybe from the pain, maybe from the tragedy of it all. "It was the only way."

Bow dropped to his knees, holding her close one last time. He could feel the slow rise and fall of her chest grow fainter. In an almost cruel way he didn't want the moment to end, didn't want that slow rhythm to stop.

But it did. The body grew still. Adora was gone.

Chapter End Notes

Hey y’all! This is set during the finale of season four but with a ~fun lil twist~

I originally wrote this before season five aired, except for the last few chapters so keep that in mind!

Hope you all enjoy :)

Facing Reality

Chapter Summary

Bow breaks the bad news to the rebellion.

Turn around.

Bow's back was to the door frame, frozen in place. Behind that slate of wood was the last piece of normality Bow would ever have again, that the rebellion would ever have again, before it was shattered into a million pieces.

Turn around.

In that room awaited the princesses, all of them confused and weakened. There were too many questions being thrown around. 'Why does the sky look like that?' 'What happened to our powers?' 'Where's Glimmer?' 'Where's Adora?'

Turn around.

Bow couldn't answer those questions. No, correction; he could but if he did then it would mean admitting to the world that both of his best friends were gone. One was hundreds of miles above them facing who knows what on an enemy ship. The other was going to be buried only a few feet below them, whenever they even had time for a funeral of course.

A funeral. The word didn't even seem real to Bow and the idea hit him with a wave of nausea. He couldn't plan a funeral. Not now.

Turn around and it will all be real.

Bow took in a shaky breath. He faced the door. The cold metal of the handle felt unwelcoming upon his palm but he pulled nonetheless. The room, which had been filled with bewildered chatter fell to a hush. Everyone's eyes locked onto Bow but he couldn't meet their gaze back. He was ashamed. Ashamed he

couldn't of stopped it. Ashamed he couldn't of been there sooner. Ashamed of what he lost.

"Bow?"

It was Perfuma. He was numbly aware of her hand guiding him to his seat. In some reassuring way, once he sat down, he could feel her hand wrapped around his, a small comfort in the very least.

The questions were on everyone's minds even though they held their tongues. *Where's Glimmer? Where's Adora?* Nobody was sure if they were allowed to ask. The puffiness around Bow's eyes, the sag in his shoulders, the red still stained on his clothes and hands. It didn't look good.

"Glimmer is..." The words got caught in his throat, paralyzing him momentarily. A squeeze of Perfuma's hand helped pull him out it. "She's...Horde Prime has her. On the ship."

Confusion and outrage rippled through the room. Bow looked up to see Micah's expression of despondency before averting his eyes back to the table.

"How did that happen?" Mermista asked. "Does it have something to do with what was messing with our powers?"

"We got to get her back!" Sea Hawk insisted, slamming his fist onto the table. "When I see Horde Prime, I'm gonna-"

Similar outbursts filled the room until Spinnerella coughed, a signal for the group to quiet their comments and allow Bow to finish.

"Well, I don't understand why we don't go now," Frosta said, visibly shaken by the loss of her mentor. "We know where the ship is so let's go. Why are we pretending like we're helpless? With She-Ra we can do anything. Why isn't Adora-"

Her rant was cut short by Bow's muffled sobs. He hadn't meant to, but he couldn't help it. A few jumped at the sound, not

expecting such a reaction. The bad feeling in their guts all worsened.

"Bow..." Perfuma asked softly, maintaining her composure the best she could for his sake. "Did something happen?"

It broke him. He couldn't hold back his tears anymore and pulled Perfuma into an embrace, sobbing heavily into her shoulder. The question, with his reaction and the blood on his shirt, seemed to answer itself at that point. Tears began to brim at a few's eyes while anger brewed in the others.

"No," Scorpia shook her head in denial. "Adora can't...that's not what was supposed to happen."

"She's gone," Bow choked out, the words lost in Perfuma's now-soaked dress.

"But she's She-Ra!" Mermista yelled out of frustration.

"Well she can't come back from the dead," Bow mumbled, lost in his own regret. "I...I watched it happen. She died in my arms. I should've been there, I-I could've stopped it."

"Oh sweetie," Netossa walked over to Bow to embrace him as well, "Don't blame yourself. The situation was out of our hands."

"It doesn't matter." Bow wiped his nose, pulling away from the girls, shrinking in on himself. "I couldn't save Glimmer and I couldn't save her."

Spinnerella came by to assist, ignoring the tears streaming silently down her own face. She rubbed Bow's back, letting him get it all out. "She wouldn't want you to blame yourself. You know that right?"

Bow nodded, somehow feeling even worse. He knew he shouldn't feel that way but how else was he suppose to feel? He looked around the room, at Scorpia comforting a hysteric Frosta, at

Mermista, Sea Hawk, and Perfuma talking quietly together, and Micah alone at the head of the table.

"We're doomed. Aren't we?" Mermista finally said.

"We can't talk like that," Perfuma said.

"But she's right," Frosta sniveled. "Without Adora we cant beat the Horde. And if Glimmer's gone too..." Her eyes widened in fear. "Is s-something going to happen to her too?"

"Not if we can help it."

The present company all turned their heads to the new voice that had spoken at the door.

"Lonnie?" Scorpia stood up, unsure if she was seeing this correctly. "Rogelio? Kyle? What are you all doing here?"

The three shared a look of determination. "We didn't mean to but we heard everything. We know what happened to your friend," Lonnie spoke for the group, "And...what happened to Adora." She paused. Was it a coincidence her eyes fell on the blonde's empty chair, even though she didn't know it was her's? Snapping out of it, she continued, "We're done with how the Horde has treated us. We want to help."

"Why should we trust you?" Bow asked meekly.

Rogelio spoke in a series of growls that honestly sounded kind of convincing.

Kyle stepped up to interpret. "What he's trying to say is, we're done fighting for people who don't even care about us. The Horde is our home but they were willing to let us die out there."

"And for what?" Lonnie interjected bitterly. "Adora had the right idea after all. If we aren't appreciated at the Horde then we might as well put our skills to use here."

"Bow was nice to me," Kyle elaborated, "Even though he didn't even know me and I was an enemy. I figure the rest of you can't be that bad either, I hope. We just want a place to belong."

The rebellion group all shared a look before Bow stepped towards the three. The ex-Horde soldiers tensed.

Bow offered them a quivering smile, the best he could muster at the time. "We'd be honored to have you on the team."

The three relaxed, relieved that the rebellion would even consider them, given their recent losses. They were invited to join the table, although the small victory seemed bittersweet considering recent events.

If anything, the three only reminded those in the room of another Horde soldier that had come to their door, asking for a second chance.

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No tears would fall from the person hidden in the rafters of the conference room, but that didn't mean they didn't feel the slightest twang of the heartstrings at the unfolding events.

Double Trouble, who had stayed within the shadows, had watched as Bow broke the unfortunate news to everyone. Even though they hadn't really known her, Double Trouble had come to respect the fallen hero.

Whether it were crocodile tears or genuine sympathy for the dearly departed, Double Trouble knew something the others didn't. This death was more than a tragedy: it was an opportunity.

Harmonious Teamwork

Chapter Summary

> Catra and Glimmer have some issues to work out. A new arrival comes to…help?

It couldn't have been more than ten minutes since Horde Prime had ordered Glimmer and Catra to the prison cells, and while they were to be kept alive, nothing seemed to be stopping them from killing each other.

"Stop staring at me."

"I'm not staring at you."

"You're literally staring right at me. It's creepy." Catra huffed. She sat in the corner farthest away from her newest companion, attempting to ignore her and failing.

"It's not like there's much else to look at," Glimmer said. She leaned against the wall, close enough to the barrier holding them in the small metal room that she could hear the buzz of electricity emanating from it.

"Aren't they suppose to teach you etiquette in princess school or are you just bad at that too?"

"You're going to lecture me on etiquette?" Glimmer laughed bitterly.

"I'm not going to do anything," Catra turned her back away. "I already got you out of one mess, I don't want to stick around long enough for you to make another."

"Hey wait a second." Glimmer jabbed a finger in Catra's direction. "Don't think we're even. Just because you saved us back there doesn't mean you're some miraculous hero now."

"Says the person who nearly nuked the planet," Catra grumbled. "Great idea that was."

"You opened a portal that tore through the fabric of reality!" Glimmer shouted. "You're the reason that I'll never see my mom again! At least I'm trying to fix my mistakes. What have you done?"

Catra stood to her feet, fists clenched. "I controlled an empire."

"Oh yeah? Look's like that got you real far, because last I checked, you still ended up with me." Glimmer looked away, figuring the conversation was over. Instead she thought about her home, the one she'd helped almost get destroyed. When she got back to Brightmoon, the first thing she'd have to do is apologize to Adora.

"I'm sorry."

"What?" Glimmer looked over at Catra who was staring down at the ground. She didn't look as angry as she did before.

"You're not going to make me say it again, are you?" Catra waited for a reply but didn't get one. Annoyed, she continued. "I just...I thought I had everything I wanted. Horde conquest, rule over Etheria, but I had it all and none of it made me happy. Now I'm left with nothing and I don't know what I want anymore."

Glimmer was quiet, contemplative. "Some friends would be a good start."

"Hey-"

"I didn't mean it in a bad way." Glimmer snapped. "I'm just saying, I might know where you're coming from."

"You?"

Glimmer shrugged. "You think after what I did, that you're the only one short on friends right now? I...pushed all of them away. I

nearly ended the world because I couldn't bite back my own pride and listen to them."

Been there, done that, Catra thought bitterly, though the guilt was there. Surprisingly, and not without some reluctance, she found she could empathize with the princess.

Glimmer shook her head. "I just want to get back to Brightmoon. Adora needs to know I'm sorry."

"I'm sure she already knows," Catra sighed. "She has that irritating little thing she does where she sees the best in people," Catra sank into herself, "Even if they can't see it themselves." Noticing Glimmer's concerned look, Catra pulled herself back together. "Let's just agree that we both have some things to say to her. And just so you know, I meant it. What I said earlier. I made some bad decisions...really bad decisions and it hurt a lot of people. I know I might not be able to make up for that but maybe getting us out of here can be a start."

Glimmer didn't ever expect to feel bad for her mother's murderer, even if it was indirect. Still, the girl she saw standing across from her and the force captain she had been fighting for months suddenly seemed like two entirely different people. She couldn't believe it herself but Glimmer was starting to understand Catra. Maybe it wouldn't be right now, or even soon, but maybe Catra really was on the right path.

"Adora still cares about you, you know," Glimmer said, catching Catra's attention. "She tries not to act like it too much, especially on missions but sometimes she'll slip up. She'll call someone by your name accidentally, out of habit I guess. Or sometimes she tells a joke only you two would get. She misses you."

Catra wasn't sure how to react. The thought of speaking to Adora again, it frustrated her and scared her and made her happy and sad and desperate all at the same time. Still, being enemies was exhausting and she'd be lying if she said she didn't miss simpler

times. They couldn't ever go back to that but was it too naive to say Catra could fix things after all?

Both girls were brought out of their contemplation when the sound of approaching footsteps echoed throughout the corridor. The guard standing alert in front of their door stepped forward towards the figure.

"Halt. Identify yourself."

The figure stopped, standing at attention. "Sentry 6-32, Squadron 78."

"Sentry 95-7, Squadron 14. As you were," The first guard ordered. 6-32 walked closer into the fluorescent lighting of the brig. Their faces were both masked by the Horde helmets on their head and their voices were raspy, all too similar to Hordak's, making Catra and Glimmer's skin crawl.

"On what orders have you come?" The first guard asked, checking the soldier's identity card for good measure.

"I've been sent to relieve you," 6-32 explained.

"Relieve me?" The guard asked. "My watch isn't over for another three hours."

"You're needed in General 2-59's chambers," answered the Sentry flatly.

The guard seemed to brighten. "Looks like our brother finally started listening to my ideas, huh?" Recovering himself he nodded, giving a small salute and walking away.

The sentry stood for a moment staring at Glimmer and Catra.

"Creepy," Catra mumbled before walking to the barrier to yell at him. "Are you going to stand there all day?"

The sentry laughed.

"What's so funny?" Catra growled. Glimmer wasn't sure whether to stop her or watch to see where this was headed. It's not like it was her fault if Catra got blasted for being an idiot.

"I hope you know I can't hear you," The sentry's laughter quelled. "A good thing too. I couldn't imagine listening to your whining all night."

Catra hissed, causing Glimmer to laugh a little too. The sentry walked over to the control panel.

"*Identification required*," The key pad sounded off in a robotic voice.

"Of course," The sentry mumbled, just loud enough to be noticeable that he wanted the prisoner's to hear it— odd considering what he said next. "I should probably remember this better, considering that one time I accidentally locked myself in that cell and had to get out using the keypad. The one under the panel to the right. Hm...now what was it. Oh! Right. 7-2-5-8-1-0." Catra's ears pricked up making a mental note of the number.

The barrier slid open but before either Catra or Glimmer could make a run for it, the sentry took out their weapon, barrel aimed right at Catra's head.

"I wouldn't try anything if I were you," The sentry said coldly, before putting the gun away to the others' confusion. "Not after the trouble I just went through."

Glimmer and Catra exchanged glances. Was this a test?

"Pink-haired one. Let's go." The sentry beckoned to Glimmer. "You're needed in the downstairs lab-" He turned to Catra with an exaggerated swivel of the head, "-Three levels down, five doors from the right."

Uneasily Glimmer stepped out of the cell, oddly enough not wanting to leave Catra behind. The electric barrier closed as soon as the two separated, leaving Catra alone.

"Well, it was nice meeting you," The sentry waved to Catra, though she couldn't tell if it was suppose to be so condescending. "I hope to see you when I get back, in the next fifteen minutes."

The sentry led Glimmer to the lift by the arm, not looking back even once. Neither of them were sure of what had just happened, but it didn't leave them with any good feelings.

Glimmer disappeared between the two sliding doors and then Catra was alone.

Guilty Party

Chapter Summary

> The newest members of the rebellion attempt to fit in with their recent allies.

Scorpia made it her responsibility to introduce Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio to their new rooms. She figured they'd probably be most comfortable with her anyways.

"You know it's actually pretty great that you guys came here when you did," Scorpia grinned as she led them down the hallway. "I only just got a room too, you'll be right next to me!"

"Sounds great," Lonnie said sarcastically, though Scorpia didn't really pick up on it.

"This'll be so fun! We can have sleepovers and share some hot gossip and- oh! We're here!" Scorpia stopped.

The doors themselves were huge but when Scorpia pushed them open, the others couldn't believe it. The inside was massive, filled with sofas, fountains and flowers.

"This is amazing!" Kyle ran over to the bed in the middle of the room, bouncing on the mattress and encouraging Rogelio to join him.

"This is all for us?" Lonnie asked Scorpia hesitantly.

"Well, yes but no," Scorpia explained. "This is just your room. Kyle and Rogelio's are next door."

"Wait really?" Kyle asked, wide eyed. "You mean we each get our own rooms?"

"This is...way too nice," Lonnie shook her head. Everything was too good to be true.

"Yeah well the rebellion is actually a lot nicer than they tell us," Scorpia said. "I mean I've only known these people for, like, a few days and they've been nothing but nice to me. Well, except for when they imprisoned me but-"

"Hey," Bow peaked his head into the room. "Sorry to interrupt but we were all going to go to the patio, light a fire and talk about..." He stopped short of finishing the sentence. "You guys are welcome to join us if you want."

"I don't know," Lonnie said. "We wouldn't want to make things weird."

Rogelio nodded his agreement.

"Alright, but if you change your mind, you know where to find us." He bid them farewell, and Scorpia followed soon after. When the ex-Horde soldiers were finally alone, they sat together.

"It might be fun to go with them," Kyle pointed out. "Maybe we can all get to know each other better."

Rogelio retaliated, shaking his head vigorously.

"Rogelio's right," Lonnie said. "They may be letting us stay here, but we have no idea if we can all trust each other yet." Fiddling with her fingers, she added, "With what happened, they probably won't want us there anyways."

They were silent for a moment.

"Do you think she's really dead?" Kyle asked. "I mean, maybe it's just a trick so they can surprise the people on that spaceship."

"I don't think it is," Lonnie said. "You saw the way they were reacting. It's not like they knew we were listening in."

"But-"

"She's gone Kyle," Lonnie snapped, before loosening up. "I'm sorry, it's just...she was a good friend before all this. I just wish we could've worked things out."

Rogelio put a hand on her shoulder, offering some words of reassurance. Even though she wasn't sure what he said, she still felt a little better about it.

"We were her friends too," Kyle said. His shoulders were drooping. "That's something we all have in common. I think we should share that instead of wasting anymore opportunities."

Lonnie looked up at him. "You really want to go to the patio?"

He nodded. Making sure Rogelio was on board as well, they made their way out of the room. Maybe Brightmoon wasn't home yet, but maybe they could make it one anyways.

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As the fire crackled in the chill night air, the members of the rebellion took in the faint breeze and tried not to think about those who wouldn't be sharing in this moment.

Bow had taken it upon himself to get drinks for everybody from the kitchen. They sipped in silence, watching the flames reach into the sky.

Everything seemed brighter now, and not just because of the fire. Growing up without the stars, you never realized how bright the universe could be. Dazzling constellations flickered above their heads, beautiful and expansive.

"Did Adora get to see this?" Frosta asked.

A few looked to Bow. "I think she's seen them a few times actually."

"But did she get to see them like this?" Frosta pointed to the sky. "For real."

Bow nodded, staring into his cup to avoid the stares of others. "Yeah. She did."

"She would think this is nice," Kyle said, causing everyone to look to him now. Blushing Kyle fidgeted in his seat. "It's just, her and Catra would always sneak out at night. We would catch them sometimes, just looking up at the sky."

"Remember that time they invited us and you fell off the roof?" Lonnie laughed.

"I didn't fall, Adora pushed me after Catra dared her to," Kyle countered, but he and Rogelio were laughing too. A few in the rebellion smiled as well.

"She never really told us about her time with the Horde," Perfuma said.

"We had some good times," Lonnie smiled reminiscently. "Catra could tell you more than we could but..." She trailed off, having forgotten how much had changed since the day Adora left. Besides, no one seemed to want to talk about her.

"She wasn't always like that you know. Catra." Scorpia pipped up. "There used to be some real good in her."

"Used to be?" Mermista asked. "You don't think there's any left."

"What?" Sea Hawk countered. "Do you want her to change sides now?"

"No," Mermista swatted him. "It was just an interesting choice of words. Scorpia was, like, really good friends with her, right?"

"Used to be," Scorpia said quietly. "She really wasn't the same after Adora left. They were both a lot happier."

"Wait, both?" Frosta said defensively. "Are you trying to say that Adora didn't like it with us?"

"No, not at all," Scorpia stood up too. She crept around the fire, the orange flames lighting up her features, flickering across her face. "It's just, Adora didn't have the weight of the world on her shoulders until she met all of you."

"Where's this coming from?" Perfuma frowned. Scorpia ignored her.

"It's the rebellion that made Adora into She-Ra." Scorpia continued. "It's the rebellion that made her think that she had to sacrifice everything for them."

"You better be careful about what you're saying," Mermista growled. "That's our friend you're talking about. Show a little respect."

"Respect?" Scorpia laughed. "Like how you all respected her? But, wasn't it the head of this rebellion that activated the weapon that killed your friend in the first place?"

"That's enough," Bow said. "We're all upset but-"

"Oh, my bad," Scorpia corrected herself. "She killed herself, right? That's how Bow claimed the story goes? Sacrificing herself to save Etheria?"

"Stop," Bow clenched a hand on his bow, even though he didn't intend to fire anything.

"One starts to wonder, would she still be alive today if it weren't for all of you," Scorpia stared at the guilty party in front of her.

Startling a few, vines shot out of the ground, wrapping themselves around Scorpia. Perfuma stepped forward standing over her newest prisoner.

"Perfuma, what are you..." Bow started but realized what Perfuma was thinking.

"You aren't the real Scorpia, are you?" Perfuma said.

Scorpia, or at least the person posing as her smiled mischievously. Shifting their form, the vines slid off of the imposter's body, revealing the truth.

"Double Trouble," Bow grimaced. "When did you get here?"

"Not long ago," Double Trouble sauntered closer to the group. "Long enough to catch myself up on the current events. I apologize for the dreary monologue but I do like to make an entrance."

"You didn't have a right to say those things about Adora," Bow said.

"No, I didn't," Double Trouble admitted. "But I had some decent points, didn't I?"

"Give me one good reason why I shouldn't blast you!" Frosta yelled, holding up her fists, now covered in ice for good measure.

"You won't be blasting me," Double Trouble said, "Or anyone else for that matter. I've only come because I could be of service."

"You really think after that stunt you just pulled, we're gonna to trust you?" Mermista asked.

"Not trust," Double Trouble grinned. "I don't have time for something as unreliable as that. No, I simply want to be on the side of the war that wins and truth be told, I don't think Mr. World Conquerer up there has my best interests in mind."

"Figures," Lonnie rolled her eyes. "They're just trying to save their own skin."

"Something I'd recommend you do as well sweetheart," Double Trouble turned to Bow. "So what do you say? Do we have a deal?"

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It wasn't that Scorpia didn't want to join the others, it's just that she lost track of time. Sitting in her room, deep in contemplation, she didn't realize what she was missing outside. She had more important things to worry about — Catra being one of them.

She wished she wasn't as concerned as she was. But with the recent losses they'd been dealt, Scorpia didn't think she could handle losing another friend, even if it was technically an ex-friend.

Was Catra safe up there? Was she a prisoner? Were they hurting her? Or was she exactly where she wanted to be?

Scorpia didn't have answers to any of those questions. Her new companions didn't seem too interested in finding out either. Scorpia knew it wasn't her job to save Catra, in fact she didn't owe Catra anything, but that didn't mean she could just stop caring.

That on top of her new...abilities was beginning to stress Scorpia out. She only had a basic understanding of her new powers. Part of her wondered if her parents would've known how to help her. It was times like these when she missed them more than ever.

Getting up, she decided to go join the others. She may of lost one family, but she didn't want to lose another. She'd convince them to get Catra back along with Glimmer. She had to.

The Test

Chapter Summary

6-32 gives Catra a choice.

Glimmer wasn't sure where she was being taken, and truth be told she wasn't eager to find out.

"Who are you?"

"I am Sentry 6-32, Squadron 78."

"Yeah, I got that," Glimmer shook her head. "I mean who are you really?"

The guard stared at her, but Glimmer couldn't tell what he was thinking behind the mask.

"I don't understand what you are asking," The guard finally said. He shifted the weapon slung over his shoulder as the elevator reached its stop. The two stepped out into an empty hallway, filled with closed doors.

"I want to know why you're helping us," Glimmer said, following him down the hallway.

"I am not helping you," The guard said. "I'm escorting you."

"But you told us-"

"I don't know what you're talking about." The guard stopped at a door. Five down from the right. "I didn't tell you or your friend anything. But if you think I did-" the door slid open, "-you should probably keep it to yourself."

Glimmer peaked into the doorway to see more Horde soldiers. Two of them were heavily armed, standing directly in front of her. The third wasn't armed, nor was he masked. Instead he wore a

lab coat and safety goggles. For a split second, Glimmer thought she was looking at Hordak until she noted the hair was different and seemed to be taller, stronger.

She turned around but 6-32 only nudged her forward into the room, before leaving her alone. The other two armed clones took their place behind her, blocking the exit. Looking back to the third, she could only imagine what he wanted with her.

"An amazing specimen, isn't she?" The scientist asked, walking slowly to Glimmer. His eyes watched her carefully, taking in every movement and every breath.

Glimmer looked behind him, seeing a metal table with straps and numerous surgical tools. Trying not to sound as nervous as she was, she asked, "What are you going to do to me?"

"So advanced," The scientist ignored her question. He prowled around her in a circle, Glimmer turning her head to keep him within sight. "How does such a lower life form hold so much magic?"

"At least I wasn't made in a bottle. Now tell me what you want with me."

The scientist didn't answer, instead walking to his work station. He picked up a small device and spoke into it. "Subject is...unruly. We will have to fix that." He spun around, addressing the guards once more. "Secure her please."

Glimmer attempted to push past them, but the door slammed in her face and she felt both her arms get pulled backwards. "Get your hands off of me!"

The guards slammed her into the table. When her head hit metal, her vision blurred and she was disoriented long enough for her arms and legs to be strapped down. "I'm not your science experiment!" She tugged on the leather straps holding her down but to no avail.

The scientist didn't seem concerned with his flailing patient. Instead, he brought the tools to the table, methodically cleaning each and every one. By the time he was done, Glimmer had settled down, out of exhaustion more than compliance.

"If you're done, I'd like to begin now." The scientist loomed over her.

"I won't tell you anything," Glimmer said. Her chest rose and fell erratically. Despite the brave face, she couldn't quell her panic.

"I am not worried about what you will or won't tell me," The scientist said. He picked up a helmet outfitted with various wires and bulbs, fitting it onto her head before looking directly at her. "I always find out everything I need."

With a click of a button, Glimmer's entire head lit up and everything went black.

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When 6-32 returned to the cells, he didn't expect to see Catra still there, but there she stood, barrier disabled and waiting.

"You shouldn't be here."

Catra stared him down. "I want to know what game you're playing."

"Are kidding me I-" The guard looked around exasperatedly, "I went through a lot of trouble to get you that code you know. I'd hate to see you waste my time."

"What game are you playing?" Catra repeated herself.

"This is not a game," The guard walked closer to Catra. "Unless you find your friend's torture to be fun."

"Torture?" Catra frowned. She kicked the guards chest, sending him spiraling backwards. Launching at him, she took the gun from

his shoulder and aimed it at his head. "You betrayed us!"

"I did my job," The guard stared back, unconcerned. "Will you do yours?"

"Why do you care what happens to us?"

The guard looked down contemplatively. "The stories of this planet have traveled farther than you realize. There are some who exist who don't share Horde Prime's agenda."

"And you're one of them?"

"I want to believe your armies can defeat him," The guard held out his hand for the gun, "But I need to know what type of people command them. I'm not trading in one villain for another."

So this is a test, Catra thought. She glanced at the elevator. If she remembered how she got to the cells correctly, that could take her back to the main deck or to some spare ships. She could escape.

"Your friend doesn't have a lot of time," The guard broke through her thoughts. "She won't be killed, but she won't be the same."

Catra was stuck. She didn't trust this guy, but she had to admit she'd still be in that cell without him. "I get to keep the gun?"

"We'll see about that." The guard snatched the gun out of her hand, slinging it back over his shoulder. "Depends on what you decide."

Catra nodded. She ran to the elevator, not sure how much time she had left. Inside, she watched the doors close on the guard who stood there silently watching. She wondered if she'd regret not pulling that trigger.

As the doors closed she examined the buttons. It was in a different language to her annoyance but luckily there were symbols next to the important ones. Her finger hovered over the level for the spaceship docks.

Three levels down, five doors from the right.

Catra grimaced. She couldn't save Glimmer on her own, right? There really was no point if they were both going to be captured again. Anyone would make the same call.

I'm not trading in one villain for another.

Catra sighed in frustration. She was indeed going to regret this.

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Glimmer didn't remember much of what happened before the door got kicked in. Truth be told, it was probably for the better. All she knew was that her entire body was in pain and the device on her head was causing it. She must've passed out a couple times given the gaps in her memory.

The scientist had dropped his tools when the door caved in. Stepping away from Glimmer, she could now see someone wrestling with the guards at the door. She wanted to help but an electrifying pulse rippled down from her skull, throughout her entire nervous system, reminding her that she didn't have a lot of options right then.

With an animalistic fury, Catra fought off the armed guards. Glimmer didn't see a lot but based on what she could hear, shots bouncing off the walls and the guards' screams were a clear indicator that Catra was winning.

When the guards were incapacitated, Catra turned to the scientist. She came closer, growling with teeth bared.

"Turn off that machine," She ordered. Another shockwave went through Glimmer as if on queue, making Catra cringe at the girl's screams.

"I won't be doing that," The scientist said calmly. He held a knife, not as impressive as the guards' guns but just as dangerous in the right hands. His form still towered over Catra.

"I wasn't giving you an option," Catra said. "Turn it off before I make you."

"It was upsetting to hear I wasn't allowed to dissect the princess," The scientist said. "He never mentioned I couldn't cut you open though."

Lunging at Catra, he swung the knife at her chest but she was quicker and dodged it, swiping his legs with her feet. As he fell to the ground, Catra kicked the knife out of his hands and flipped over him, grabbing it midair. On her feet, she swiveled on her heels and faced the scientist, who was in the process of standing up. She went to punch him in the jaw but he caught her hand and twisted it behind her back. Catra tossed the knife, the small weapon landing on the table holding Glimmer down.

The scientist grabbed for his tools and clenched some thin plastic tubing. Wrapping it around Catra's neck, he held her in a chokehold. Luckily she was able to get a hand in between her and the plastic but she couldn't hold out for long.

As this happened, Glimmer was busy trying to get a hold of the knife. Despite the electricity firing into her brain, she managed to grip the weapon and wedge it in between her wrist and the leather cuff. Slicing a few times as hard as she could, the arm band snapped in two. Taking the machine off of her head, she ripped off the other cuffs and shakily got to her feet. Helmet in hand, she slammed it onto the scientists head before diving for the control panel.

With a twist of a dial, the helmet fired at maximum power. He instantly released Catra and stumbled backwards, body jolting from the massive amounts of electricity.

Leaving him to fry, Glimmer helped Catra up who was struggling to catch her breath.

"We need to hurry," Catra said, voice hoarse. "The ship docks, we-
"

She froze when her eyes met the doorway. A half dozen guards lined the exit way, two more approaching fast. Glimmer looked as though she was getting ready to fight but Catra held her back. "Not yet. This isn't the fight we're supposed win."

Glimmer looked at her uncertainly, but the determined look in Catra's eyes reassured her. She stood down.

Accepting defeat, the girls raised their hands in the air, allowing the guards to escort them back to the cells.

When they reached the cell, they found it unguarded. As they were locked back up, they saw their original guard was approaching.

"What's going on? Where's Sentry 6-32?" The guard asked.

"Right here," The sentry stepped out of the unit, surprising Catra and Glimmer. They hadn't realized he was there. "Capturing your prisoners after you abandoned your post."

The original guard started yelling obscenities. "You sent me away! I was set up!" The squadron ignored his hysteria, instead proceeding to handcuff him.

"Horde Prime will be very disappointed in you," 6-32 said. Turning to the soldiers left, he said, "I will take his post. That is, until our brother is feeling better again."

The guards nodded, taking the original guard away and leaving the three alone once more. Only once the shouts of the original guard died out did someone finally say something.

"So?" Catra asked. "Did I pass?"

The guard couldn't hear her but understood what she must of said given the response.

"Not yet."

A New Kind of Promise

Chapter Summary

> While Bow is faced with an unexpected dilemma, Glimmer and Catra begin to understand each other.

Of all the things Bow could have dealt with the following morning, a stolen spaceship was by far the most surprising.

"What do you mean it's just gone?" His voice cracked as he paced the empty area where the ship should've been.

"We were going to tell you earlier but then..." Perfuma faltered. "You just had enough problems to worry about."

"How do you lose an entire spaceship? It's huge!"

"Well," Perfuma clutched her arm, looking away, "After the whole energy-stealing thing, Frosta and I went to go check on the ship and..."

"And?" Bow pressed for more.

"The person was already in the ship when we got to the clearing and they took off," Perfuma admitted ashamedly. "We both tried to stop it but as weak as we were...I'm sorry Bow. We didn't get a good look at them but we were sure it was trying to reach the bigger ship. And then...Horde Prime shot it down. The whole thing...just gone."

"That doesn't make any sense," Bow groaned, massaging the back of his neck. Looking up at Perfuma, he saw how upset she was. Relaxing, Bow walked over to her. "It's not your fault."

"But it's our only way to get to Prime's ship," Perfuma said. "I-I'm sorry but things are not looking very bright right now. I'm having a hard time staying positive about all this."

"We'll find another way," Bow reassured her, and himself partially. So they didn't have a method to get onto Prime's ship. The place where Glimmer was being held. Prisoner, most likely. It was rather bleak now that he thought about it.

"Um, excuse me." A hand tapped on Bow's shoulder, except it wasn't a hand. It was hair.

"Entrapta?" Bow looked around wildly. Laughing nervously, he asked "Where did you come from?"

"I heard you were having trouble with your ship," Entrapta said, unpacking her tools in the empty clearing.

Bow and Perfuma exchanged glances.

"Yes, well," Bow said hesitantly, "The issue is that it doesn't exist anymore."

"Not with that attitude!" Entrapta laughed to the confusion of her peers. Realizing they'd need an explanation, she continued, "Give me until the afternoon at best. I already sent out my bots to retrieve the bigger pieces. The rest I should be able to adapt from my old things, although I may need to borrow from-"

"You're going to rebuild the ship," Perfuma said rather than asked, mouth agape.

"What did you think we were going to do?" Waving a wrench at the two playfully, she remarked, "If I have a chance to build a spaceship, I'm going to build a spaceship."

Bow found his hopes rising. "This is amazing! You know, if you need some help, I can always-"

"I will need your help actually."

"Really?" Bow bounced on his heels. He was going to actually build something with his idol.

"First ones tech," Entrapta said. "I won't be able to get this thing working without it. You wouldn't happen to have any, would you?"

Oh, Bow thought disappointedly.

"I'm sure we have something laying around," Perfuma said. Turning to Bow, she leaned in close. "We...we do have something laying around, right?"

Bow nodded contemplatively. Straightening up, he looked Entrapta in the eyes. "What about a sword?"

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Glimmer found it hard to tell how much time had passed in the prison cell, seeing as there were no windows, no clocks, and the only evidence that the world was still moving was the occasional shifting of 6-32 or Catra's mumbles in her sleep.

She didn't mean to stare. There was just something peaceful about watching her. Unconscious, Catra was a lot less intimidating than Glimmer took her for. The girl was curled into a ball, expression scrunched into a scowl even asleep.

Glimmer was tired too, but they agreed it could be dangerous for them both to fall asleep. Catra had offered Glimmer the first chance to get some shut-eye but as hard as she tried, Glimmer couldn't ease her mind so she gave up and let Catra rest instead.

Now, Glimmer sat on the floor, facing the forcefield, the wall supporting her back. Her head was still throbbing, but the fuzziness was clearing up. She could focus again.

And so, Glimmer focused on Catra's breathing. It was slow and rhythmic and it helped Glimmer think. Think of what exactly? There was plenty on her mind. Escape. The Heart of Etheria. Adora.

Clenching her fists and drawing her legs up to her chest, Glimmer felt horrible. She had time to practice her apology she supposed.

Glimmer was snapped out of her thoughts when she noticed Catra's breathing grow more rapid. Gradually, the frown on her face turned to fear, despair. Even though she was still asleep, Catra started twisting and turning, eventually shouting out.

Rushing to her side, Glimmer grabbed Catra's shoulders, attempting to wake her from her nightmares. Opening her eyes, Catra hissed, clawing at Glimmer who jumped backwards.

"Watch it!" Glimmer shouted harshly. She faltered though when she got a good look at Catra.

For a moment, Catra didn't seem to understand where she was, still stuck in the dream. She was leaning away from Glimmer, holding her upper body up with trembling arms. Her breathing was erratic. She looked terrified and if Glimmer looked closely, she thought she saw tears welling up in her eyes.

Regaining her bearings, the fear slowly left, the breathing settled. Realizing Glimmer had seen everything, Catra hastily turned away.

At first Glimmer wasn't sure what to do. Should she comfort her? Ignore it? Neither felt right exactly. Catra seemed to make that decision for her.

"I wish you hadn't seen that."

Glimmer couldn't help her own curiosity. "What were you dreaming of?"

Catra sat there, silent for a long time. Glimmer wondered if she'd overstepped. Finally though, Catra mumbled, "Same thing I dream of every night."

"You go through that every night?"

Catra nodded. "Ever since...yeah, it's every night." Glimmer knew she was holding something back but she didn't press. Instead she switched gears.

"I've been meaning to ask you something," Glimmer said. She leaned to the side, trying to catch Catra's eye but the latter remained turned away from her. "Why did you go back for me? We both know you would've escaped on your own."

"We don't know that for sure," Catra avoided the question. "Who knows what I would've run into." Risking a glance at Glimmer, she regrettably made eye contact, making her snap her head away again. "I just needed you as an extra fighter or whatever. Don't look into it too much. You aren't special."

Glimmer smiled slightly. "Do you want to know why I think you did it?"

"Do I have a choice?" Catra grumbled.

"I think that you're warming up to me."

"Absolutely not!" Catra spun around angrily to be met with Glimmer's victorious smirk.

"You enjoy my company," Glimmer teased. "Admit it."

"You are the bane of my existence," Catra growled. "We literally were trying to kill each other only a few hours ago. What makes you think I would- stop smiling!"

As frustrated as Catra was, maybe she had to admit she didn't want to fight Glimmer as badly as she usually did. And maybe it was true that she didn't regret going for Glimmer instead of an escape pod. And she wasn't thinking about her nightmare anymore, something that usually haunted her for much longer.

"Well thank you," Glimmer broke into Catra's thoughts. "My brain would probably be cooked if you didn't intervene."

"You're telling me? Take it from someone who's been regularly electrocuted since before I can remember, I'm surprised you lasted as long as you did."

Catra had said it so nonchalantly, Glimmer almost didn't react. When she processed the words however, Glimmer lost her joking tone.

"That happened to you as a kid?" Glimmer frowned.

Catra looked at Glimmer as if she shouldn't be surprised. "Uh, yeah. I was a screwup. Shadow Weaver didn't just decide to hate me yesterday. I've been dealing with her my whole life. Honestly, she only kept me around because of Adora. Otherwise..." Catra picked at her nails. "It doesn't matter really. That's just what happens when you step out of line. Or exist, in my case."

Glimmer thought back to the first time her and Shadow Weaver worked together. Shadow Weaver had used Glimmer's magic to electrocute Catra. With a sinking feeling in her stomach, Glimmer remembered how she had done the same thing not so long after.

"Why are you looking at me like that?" Catra asked.

"I'm sorry."

Catra shrugged. "It's whatever, I'm just gonna assume you have a staring problem."

"Not for that," Glimmer scooted closer to Catra. "I'm sorry for...everything. Nobody should have to grow up like that."

Catra blinked a few times. "Oh."

"I'm serious," Glimmer said, growing angrier by the second. "That's just wrong. You shouldn't have to be in fear all the time or-or hurt. No wonder you've made the decisions you have!" Glimmer was rambling on now, cursing about Shadow Weaver, wondering aloud why Adora never mentioned it before, realizing she probably would've reacted the same way Catra did. "You don't deserve a life like that."

Catra just sat there silently, listening in amazement. And then she did something she didn't expect.

Cutting Glimmer off, she found herself hugging her former enemy. Gripping on tightly, she wasn't letting go.

Shocked, Glimmer slowly embraced her back. Catra let everything lose, the tears returning as she felt something she'd never felt before: release. Glimmer let her, knowing it was what Catra needed.

When she finally pulled away, Catra felt embarrassed but at the same time safer than she had been in a long time. Wiping at her eyes, she didn't know what to say. The two girls just sat across from each other, taking the moment in.

"Hey," Glimmer placed a hand on Catra's knee, smiling warmly at her. "We're going to get off this ship. Together. I promise."

Catra knew Glimmer didn't know what those words meant to her, but they still hit home. "Together," Catra agreed.

"And Catra?" Glimmer said. "I want you to know that when we do escape, there's a place in Brightmoon for you. If you'll take it."

"I don't know if I deserve that," Catra said truthfully. "I've done...a lot of bad things."

"Then start doing some good," Glimmer said. "It's already in you. I've seen it. You just have to try."

There were a million things Catra wanted to say right then but as it turns out she wouldn't get to say any. Instead, her eyes darted away from Glimmer and to the opening elevator doors. Glimmer turned too, heart beating faster when she saw who it was.

"The scientist," Glimmer mumbled.

The man shuffled closer, his legs weakly supporting his hunched over figure. His face was covered in burns from the electricity and as he approached he kept clenching and unclenching his jaw. His eyes were zeroed in on Glimmer.

With this new arrival, 6-32 sprung up. "You aren't authorized to be down here."

"Silence!" The scientist barked.

Unwavering, 6-32 placed himself between the scientist and the cell. "I need you to leave immediately. The prisoners are not allowed-"

"Do not tell me what I can or can't do!" The scientist grabbed at the sentry's neck, picking him up and tossing him aside. Landing roughly, 6-32 laid on the ground unmoving.

The scientist punched in some numbers on the keypad, opening the cell. Glimmer backed away and Catra stood between the two.

"You're going to pay for what you did to me," The scientist growled. His eyes were bulging out of his head. "Look what you did to me!"

"I'd do it again," Glimmer glared.

"Move aside," He ordered Catra. When she didn't move, he lunged for her. She jumped up out of the way, but he knew what to expect now and swung his arm like a battering ram, hitting her in the stomach and sending her crashing aside. Swiping for Glimmer, he clutched her wrist and tugged her forward.

"My perfect form!" The scientist wailed. "Ruined! A wretched embarrassment! I'll drain you as a battery, girl, to fuel an entire fleet of ships. I'll make you feel the pain I felt, scar you the way you scarred me!"

Glimmer tried to twist out of his grasp, punching and kicking him but he wouldn't relent. Dragging her out to the elevators, Catra tried to run after them but the forcefield slammed closed, cutting them off. She tried to open it the way she did before, but the code didn't work anymore, most likely changed after their first escape.

As the elevator doors sealed shut, cutting the two girls off from each other, Catra felt hopeless. Her first chance at a real friend since Adora and she'd already lost it.

At this point, 6-32 had recovered and gotten to his feet. Catra felt rage trembling through her whole body.

"Why didn't you do more?" Catra shouted. "You have a gun, why didn't you-"

The guard made his way to the panel, putting in a code himself. From Catra's side, nothing seemed to happen.

"I can hear you now," 6-32 said.

"Good!" Catra spat. "Now let me out of here. Or better yet, help me save Glimmer."

"I can't move against him," 6-32 said slowly. "I can't make myself a target, can't bring attention to myself. I've already pushed my luck today. Besides, they changed the entry code. I cant open the doors. I'm sorry but my hands are tied."

Catra pounded on the force field, "She'll die if you don't help her."

"No," The guard said matter-of-factly. "She'll die if you don't."

"I did everything I could!" Catra begged. "How am I suppose to do anything while I'm in here? You said you would help us if I saved her."

"I said I'd help you if you passed my test, which you still haven't."

"How? I did everything you asked."

"Because you thought it would get you out of here faster, not because you wanted to help."

"That's not true." Catra jabbed a finger at him. "I could've left Glimmer ages ago, you have to know that."

"You keep her close because it keeps you alive. There's a difference."

Catra held back a scream. What did this guard know about anything? He wasn't there in that cell just then.

"Then what else do you want me to do?" Catra asked. "How do I pass your stupid test?"

"If you have to ask, then you aren't the person I was hoping you'd be."

The guard left, going to who knows where and leaving Catra alone.

Sinking down in defeat, Catra didn't know what to do. She wished she was back on solid ground. She wished she hadn't gotten them into this situation, wished she had just listened to Adora and never opened that stupid portal that brought Prime here in the first place. She wished she could talk to Adora now, strangely enough, though she didn't know what to say. That she missed her was a start. That she wished she wasn't alone anymore.

Deep down, she knew she couldn't get her hopes up though. Despite what Glimmer said, Catra knew she had simply pushed some people too far. The fact that Glimmer was even giving her a chance made it all the more important that she had to get her back.

Catra didn't think she could handle losing anyone else.

Missing Piece

Chapter Summary

> With the spaceship nearing completion, the rebellion comes up with a plan to board Prime’s ship — but they may not be ready for what’s waiting for them.

As Bow led Entrapta and Perfuma to his room in the palace, he wasn't sure if what he was doing was the right call. On one hand, it's not like they needed the sword anymore but on the other...it was almost like handing over a piece of Adora, something that was in short supply these days.

"Can you really build a spaceship in one day?" Perfuma asked Entrapta.

"I didn't have plenty of time to study it when we returned from Beast Island, but I've been attempting to make one for quite some time. The difficulty is just finding compatible tech."

"Well hopefully this will work," Bow stopped in front of his door. "It's all we have."

The door creaked open and the others waited outside while Bow went in. He made his way to the dresser by his bed, opening the top drawer. Inside laid what was left of the sword of protection. The hilt was still connected to the jagged metal. He tried to ignore the red stains that were still on the edges. The runestone that used to shine so spectacularly looked dulled in the unlit room.

Taking it in his hands gently, he rejoined the others. Part of him didn't want to hand it over to Entrapta, but he did.

"Be careful with it," Bow said, to which Entrapta smiled sincerely. Her and Perfuma left to return to the clearing. Looking out the window, Bow could already see a pile of scrap metal building up. He turned to go to the training center when someone caught his eye.

Shadow Weaver, he thought. Ever since Glimmer disappeared, she had been acting really strange. He remembered how she reacted when he told her what happened to Adora. All of that suave confidence fell and she hasn't said a thing since. She just watches in the shadows, listening in to conversations. Bow really wished she'd just leave already but he wasn't about to start that fight.

Ignoring her, he left, deciding he would just go help Entrapta instead. Oddly enough, he didn't want to be on his own anymore. Especially not in a room full of weapons.

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Glimmer didn't know what to expect, other than that whatever was about to happen was going to hurt.

Taken to the same room as before, she noticed the equipment was still lying as they left it: some instruments thrown to the ground, others malfunctioning and sparking. The machine that had been shoved into the scientists head had been pulled out of the wall. Glimmer was at least happy she wouldn't have to deal with that thing again.

The scientist kept a deathly grip on her. Not even prying at his fingers got him to loosen his hold. Glimmer considered biting him but before she could, he slammed the door shut, sealing them in the laboratory. Not wasting any time, he used his other hand to grab Glimmer by the hair and bang her head against the wall.

He let go of her but she was too dizzy to do anything. That, paired with her already existing headache, made for some foggy vision.

The scientist grabbed her again by the shoulder and threw her into the wall. Groaning, she tried to push against it to hold herself up when she felt two metal spikes stab into her back. Letting out a scream of agony, Glimmer dropped to the floor.

Twisting her head, she saw that the metal prods were connected to some wiring from a machine on the wall. Bracing herself for

what she guessed was coming, she saw the scientist slam down a switch on the wall.

Glimmer must of momentarily blacked out, because for a second she couldn't see and then she was writhing on the ground. The pain was different from before, more like when she had been captured by the Horde. This time though, instead of feeling the black garnets disrupting her magic, she felt her own powers fighting against her body. Every cell was on fire, lit up by the same magic she had learned to master.

"I told you," The scientist gripped her face, "I'm going to drain you until there's nothing left." Letting her fall back to the floor, Glimmer let loose another scream. She didn't even know what she was saying anymore. She just wanted it to stop.

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Morning turned to midday and midday turned to evening. As the hours passed, nearly every member of the rebellion was checking in on the progress of the ship (to the slight annoyance of Entrapta, though she didn't mind talking while she worked).

With Bow's help and the occasional help of the princesses, everyone was happily surprised that Entrapta hadn't been in over her head. She really was going to finish this. Everyone just hoped it could fly.

As Entrapta finished, all she had left to do was implement the sword's runestone into the ship. For this, she advised everybody to wait a good distance away, seeing as most of these things tend to have explosive results.

Bow, Perfuma, and Frosta stood by the castle wall, watching the ship from a distance. Mermista and Scorpia, who were on their way anyways, joined them.

"Hey guys," Bow greeted. "What's up?"

"Me and Scorps were talking and, like, we had a question," Mermista said.

"We'd just like to know the plan once the ship is done?" Scorpia asked.

"Also like what exactly is stopping us from getting blown out of the sky?" Mermista crossed her arms. "Just a thought."

Bow hadn't thought of that truthfully. It was a valid point. Prime had shot at a ship that he himself might of stolen. What's to stop him from doing it again?

"Aha!" Joyous laughter could be heard from across the clearing. Everyone turned to see the lights slowly blink on. Steadily the ship rose, hovered for a moment, and set back down. Entrapta came running over to them, grinning widely. "We are cleared for take off! Now, I didn't have time to add a lot of the things I wanted to but this should be easier to maneuver than the old model."

"Hey! We were wondering, is it possible that you added an invisibility ray or maybe a way to hide us once we're in the air?" Perfuma asked.

"Oh no, that would take weeks to figure out, but it's a great idea!" Entrapta took out her recording device and walked away, jabbering into it about stealth tech.

"We don't have time to wait until she can hide us," Bow said. "Every second we waste down here is another second Glimmer could be in danger."

"Then we should be going now," Frosta insisted. "Come on, let's get the others."

"Wait, wait, wait," Mermista stopped Frosta from running off. "So if their big scary ship starts firing at our small not-so-scary ship, what do you expect us to do?"

"The explosion was big Bow," Perfuma admitted. "I don't think whoever was flying our's survived."

"It could've been a robot or something," Frosta said. "It's one of my theories. I have another one where-"

"We aren't backing down," Bow said. "I'll go alone if I have to. We're rescuing Glimmer because she wouldn't hesitate to rescue any of us. It's worth the risk."

"Um, on that note," Scorpia looked around nervously, "I actually wanted to ask if we could rescue Catra as well?"

"Why would we want to do that?" Frosta asked.

"It's just, I mean she's on that ship too and I just thought..." Scorpia was way too aware of the strange looks she was receiving. "I'm just saying, she doesn't deserve to be on that ship any more than Glimmer does."

"You're right," Bow said, though not happily. "We don't know what Horde Prime's capable of, meaning we don't know if he'll hurt Catra or not."

"Who's to say she's not exactly where she wants to be?" Mermista asked. "For all we know, she's on Horde Prime's side. I don't think it's worth it."

"We don't leave people behind," Bow said.

"Catra doesn't count," Mermista argued. "In case you forgot, she destroyed my kingdom."

"Then at least let us bring her in to Brightmoon," Scorpia insisted. "We can keep her here." Mermista and Frosta still didn't look convinced. "Please?"

"All we can offer her is a chance," Bow said. "I can't guarantee you anything though."

Scorpia would just have to accept that as an answer. With that decided, Bow left to go get the rest of the group. Seeing as the ship was operational, they had to do this now. There wasn't any time to lose.

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It was decided that not everyone should go on the ship as planned. With the whole possibly-getting-blown-up thing on everyone's minds, it wasn't the smartest move to have the entire rebellion in the air.

Entrapta would fly the ship. Bow, Scorpia, and Micah would join her. Frosta insisted she come too, but Entrapta explained that she wouldn't be much help, seeing as the distance from the runestone would make her powers useless.

Everyone else would stay on the ground.

As the group split, everyone's nerves were on edge. They didn't discuss what would happen if the ship got shot at, or worse: shot down. Everyone simply knew with their latest string of luck, they were bound for some good news and they might as well hope this was it.

In the cockpit, Bow saw that Entrapta had changed the control panels. They weren't so reliant on First One tech and had more modern controls. She had also added more seats, a nice touch. At the very front of the panel, Bow could see the hilt plugged into the ship, the runestone pulsing lightly.

Buckling up his seatbelt, Bow couldn't help but stare at the massive ship looming over them. He wasn't even sure how he was suppose to find Glimmer in a place like that but it was something he'd need to figure out when he got to it.

Entrapta flipped on a few switches, the ship groaning as it woke up. Taking a deep breath, she glanced back at the others reassuringly before focusing on the steering. "Preparing for takeoff in three...two..."

The ship blasted into the air faster than its passengers were prepared for. Seatbelts jabbing into their bodies, they gripped onto their seats as the land beneath them grew smaller.

"Breaching the atmosphere in five...four...three...two...one."

The ship slammed to a halt, or at least it felt that way. As it virtually slowed down to nothing, the pressure in everyone's heads dispersed and their limbs felt lighter than they ever had before.

"It's beautiful," Entrapta gasped. The others turned to look out the window and found themselves in awe as well. The stars and planets that surrounded them looked different above the clouds.

If only the Horde ship wasn't blocking part of their view.

"So Bow," Micah asked calmly, "At what point exactly was the old ship shot down?"

"Good question," Bow squeaked. "I'm not exactly sure."

"I'm sure we'll be fine," Scorpia laughed nervously. "We'll be fine, right?"

As the ship edged closer to the battle cruiser, the four weren't feeling as confident as they hoped. That is — until Entrapta noticed something.

"That's odd," Entrapta squinted. "Is it just me or does it seem like this side of the ship's controls are down?"

Bow leaned forward in his seat, taking a good look as well. Looking at the rest of the ship, everything was glowing an ominous green, the weapons engaged and routinely swiping the area. In the spot where they were approaching though, the ship was dark and the weapons were turned off.

Was it dumb luck? Or was something else going on? A trap maybe?

Whether it was a wise decision or not, Entrapta flew faster towards the docking bay. If this was luck, then they couldn't waste it. And if it wasn't...hopefully they weren't rushing towards their doom.

Without so much as a hiccup, the docking bay opened at the presence of the ship and Entrapta was able to land quietly. The room itself was completely dark.

"Any idea what's waiting out there for us?" Scorpia asked nervously.

"Only one way to find out." Bow took his bow in hand, readying an arrow. Leading the group, his hand hovered over the doorway, before swinging the entrance open.

At first, they couldn't see anything. With the room so dimly lit, they couldn't make out more than a few feet in front of them. Motioning for them to continue, Bow crept further out into the room, making it all the way to the exit.

"Why isn't anyone here?" Micah asked. "Shouldn't this whole ship be guarded?"

"You would think," Bow eyed the closed doors, trying to make out anything from the cracks in the frame. Surely enough, he saw a shadow, singular but just as terrifying. There was definitely someone waiting on the other side.

The others readied themselves for a fight. Bow pressed a button on the keypad and the doors slid open revealing a single Horde soldier.

Everyone was ready to attack when to their surprise the soldier held their hands in the air. Faltering, they weren't sure what to do.

"I'm not here to fight," The guard explained. "I'm here to help."

"Who are you?" Bow asked, arrow aimed for his chest.

"Sentry 6-32, Squadron 78. I'm a friend."

The others weren't convinced.

"Don't you wonder why you were able to board so easily?" 6-32 asked. "I disabled the weapons. I'm on your side. Time, however, is not. Your friends are in danger. I can take you to them."

"You're going to have to give us more if you want us to trust you," Bow said.

The guard sighed. "Listen, I'm your only chance. You can come with me, or you can waste time searching a ship bigger than Brightmoon."

Bow, Micah, Entrapta and Scorpia turned to each other.

"What should we do?" Scorpia whispered.

"We may never find Glimmer if we don't follow him," Micah said. "I'm not risking it."

Bow nodded. He could see how all of this was weighing on him. Bow couldn't imagine the disappointment Micah must of felt when he realized he wouldn't be seeing his daughter after all.

"Alright," Bow turned back to 6-32. "Lead the way."

The guard nodded, immediately setting off down the hall. The others followed.

"No one should follow us," 6-32 explained. "I had this section of the ship cleared, but it won't last for long." He led them to an elevator and punched in a code. The others waited impatiently, uneasy with being confined in such a small space with their new companion.

Alas, the guard made no moves against them and when the elevator doors open, he diligently led them to where they were suppose to be.

That being said, it wasn't what they had in mind.

In front of them was a prison cell, but Glimmer was nowhere to be seen. Instead, there sat Catra, looking just as bewildered as them, if not more.

"Catra?" Scorpia frowned. Scorpia couldn't help but notice that Catra seemed different, less rigid, less angry and just sad.

"What is this?" Micah turned on 6-32. "Where's my daughter?"

"You'll fail without her," 6-32 motioned to Catra. "You, the scientist, I need you to open her cell."

Entrapta happily obliged, eager to get a closer look at Prime's tech. Bow stood there conflicted as Scorpia and Catra talked through the barrier and Micah and 6-32 argued.

"How long is this going to take?" Micah demanded. "I need to bring Glimmer home."

"Like I said-" 6-32 stopped, turning his head to the side. He was listening to his communicator. "I have to go. Your ship has been noticed." Beginning to run to the elevator, he shouted back, "Catra knows where Glimmer is! Stay together!"

Left to fend for themselves, all eyes turned to Catra, except for Entrapta who was still firing away at the control panel.

Even though she was behind the force field, Bow still felt uneasy. Not once had he had a positive interaction with Catra and he doubted that would change now. Who's to say she wouldn't turn on them as soon as that barrier lifted?

"Where's Glimmer at?" Micah asked desperately. "I'll go ahead myself."

"I can show you once you let me out," Catra said, not confident they'd bother if they had what they needed.

"Typical," Bow said. "Entrapta, how are we doing?"

"Just another minute!" Entrapta called.

"Tell me where my daughter is!" Micah pounded on the force field, growing restless.

Catra didn't know what to do. She did desperately want to get out and she did want to save Glimmer, but who's to say them wasting time on her wouldn't be Glimmer's downfall. Reluctantly, she decided she'd have to risk it. "Take the elevator. Three floors down and five doors to the right. She was taken by some crazy scientist guy."

Micah was already racing towards the elevator. While Entrapta didn't move, Bow found himself stuck at a crossroads.

"Go," Scorpia reassured him. "We'll handle everything here."

Nodding, Bow raced off to join Micah. Scorpia looked to Catra, both anxiously waiting for the barrier between them to drop.

"Scorpia I'm..." Catra looked down ashamedly. "I'm sorry about, well, everything. I've been a bad friend and ended up treating you the same way I resented people for treating me. I understand if you don't want anything to do with me."

"Do you really think I'd be here if I didn't want anything to do with you?" Scorpia smiled warmly. "I appreciate the apology though. When we get out of here, we'll have a talk."

"I'd like that," Catra said quietly.

"Got it!" Entrapta cheered. Instead of the barrier lifting though, Catra jumped back as the control panel exploded in sparks and the barrier faltered completely. Alarms blared throughout the corridor.

Entrapta gave the group a thumbs up. "Time to go!"

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When Bow and Micah made it to the lab, they heard what was happening before they saw it. Lying on the ground was Glimmer, metal rods sticking out of her back, muscles spasming weakly as her magic was being drained out of her body. She was pale, covered in sweat, and, worst of all, screaming, begging, for it to end. Otherwise, the room was empty.

Rushing to Glimmer's side, Micah scooped up his daughter, holding her and trying to ease her suffering. Bow followed the wires to the machine and smashed it with his boots until it shut off. He, too, joined Glimmer, helping to remove the rods and stop the bleeding.

"D-Dad?" For a moment Glimmer was scared that she had died and was seeing her father in some strange afterlife. When she looked around though, she could tell that she was still on the Horde ship.

She tried to stand up but could barely push herself to her feet. Her limbs were too weak, her body still jolting here and there. The only thing she could focus on was her own breathing, and even that was labored.

"Let's get her out of here," Bow grabbed Glimmer's legs so the two could carry her out when suddenly he felt his body give out under him.

On the floor, he looked to see who he assumed was the deranged scientist Catra had mentioned earlier. The scientist was busy trying to overpower Micah, who luckily had seen him coming. The two wrestled on the floor while Bow dragged Glimmer out of harm's way.

"I've had enough of you people!" The scientist yelled as he slammed his fist into Micah's jaw, knocking him out cold. Bow ran up to stop him but the scientist swatted him away too. Landing on

the ground, Bow felt the wind get knocked out of him. He couldn't get up.

Spinning on his heels towards Glimmer, the scientist took out his gun and aimed it at her head. She didn't even have enough energy to look at him, her head drooping over her chest.

"So long princess."

"Technically, she's a queen."

Glimmer didn't get a good look at who said that before the scientist squeezed the trigger.

A blur flashed in front of Glimmer's eyes and she was surprised to find she was unharmed (or at least not any more harmed than she already was).

Bow, having regained his bearings, shot a bludgeoning arrow at the man, knocking him out and sending him to the floor. He then raced to Glimmer's side.

"Are you ok?" Bow asked hurriedly.

Glimmer nodded lazily. "What...w-who?"

Bow turned to realize what she meant. Scorpia and Entrapta were crowded around Catra, who was lying on the floor.

"Oh no," Scorpia kept repeating to herself. "Oh no, oh no."

"Relax," Catra grunted. "I just got grazed in the shoulder."

With everyone who could still walk now on their feet, they quickly made a game plan. Bow and Catra would help get Glimmer to the ship. Scorpia could carry Micah, and Entrapta would take the gun, leading the way.

It must've been a miracle but they weren't stopped by any guards in the hallway, nor in the elevator. Everything was smooth sailing

until they got to the ship deck.

6-32 was waiting anxiously for them. "You did it?"

"No need to sound so surprised," Catra said. "Are we leaving or not?"

"Follow me," 6-32 said. "I had to move your ship. Luckily with the alarms, everyone cleared out of here. Good thinking, whoever's idea that was."

"Yes, that was definitely intentional," Entrapta nodded eagerly.

Making it to ship, the others piled in. 6-32 was about to board as well when Catra stopped him.

"What do you think you're doing?" Catra glared.

"I'm coming with you."

"No, you aren't."

"Really?" 6-32 laughed. "So first you're mad because you want to pass my test, then, you finally pass it and you don't want the reward? I told you I can help."

The two could hear footsteps not far away. They were about to have company.

"Fine," Catra waved him inside. "Let's just go."

Loaded up, the ship closed it's doors and shot out into the sky, putting as much distance between them and the ship as possible.

"The weapons system should still be down," 6-32 reassured everyone. "It took me ages to disable them, meaning it'll take just as long for them to turn back on. They can't shoot at us."

Despite that fact, Entrapta still made sure they reached the ground as soon as possible.

Glimmer was lying on the floor. Micah had woken up and was now sitting over her, performing a spell. As he did, everyone could see the color returning to her skin.

"What are you doing?" Bow asked curiously.

"Returning some magic to her," Micah said, "At least until we can get her to the runestone."

Bow sat with her, keeping a hand on hers. He looked around to assess the others. Entrapta was busy flying, while 6-32 asked her questions, pointing to the sword connected to the ship. Catra sat with Scorpia, poking at her wound.

"I don't think you should do that," Scorpia cringed. It was only a skin deep cut but it freaked her out regardless.

Huffing, Catra quit it and looked around at the crew. She was honestly surprised that there was no one else on the ship.

Catra decided to ask Scorpia the question on her mind. "So. Where's Adora?"

Scorpia's shoulders dropped. She knew this was inevitable but it didn't make it any worse. Looking at the others, she saw that Glimmer had heard Catra, and was now asking Bow the same thing.

Catra noticed too. She saw the looks Bow and Micah had. They didn't bode well.

"Scorpia?" Catra asked. "What's wrong?"

"Well, you see Wildcat. Something...happened," Scorpia started.

"What is it?" Catra was growing more frustrated. "Did she not want to come? Did she not want to save us?"

"No," Scorpia shook her head, "That's not-I mean technically she saved everyone."

Catra looked to see Glimmer was crying now over something Bow said. "Scorpia, what's going on?"

Scorpia took a deep breath. "I need you to promise me something. Promise you aren't going to shut yourself out after this."

"Why won't you just give me a straight answer?"

"Just tell me you won't push us away."

"Not until you tell me where Adora's at." Catra tried to ignore Glimmer's conversation, tried to ignore whatever could've elicited such a reaction. "I still have to talk to her, I have so much to say. Scorpia?"

The next thing that came out of Scorpia's mouth washed over Catra, gradually at first. Scorpia went on, probably explaining what happened but Catra had already stopped listening. Everything else went out of focus, played around her like static, and all Catra could hear were those same two words on loop.

Adora died.

The Funeral

Chapter Summary

Did you ever watch your life slide out of your hands?
(Regret, regret)
You wish it never had
(Regret, regret)
But all of that's in the past

Chapter Notes

AKA “Regret” by Everything Everything is the perfect fit for this story

Even though it was only a matter of time that this was going to happen, it oddly enough didn't really make anyone feel better. On one hand, it would be nice to finally have a final goodbye for their friend, but on the other hand, they didn't want to say goodbye at all.

The funeral was closed casket. It would take place in the afternoon, and would be a private ceremony. The rest of the kingdom could mourn her later, they decided. Today was just for them.

They wanted to have it as soon as possible, meaning not even a full day had passed since Glimmer and Catra's rescue, so of course there was a lot on everyone's minds.

Bow had only just finished getting ready. He stood in front of the mirror, though his reflection seemed strange and distorted to him. Too clean. Too somber. His hair was neatly trimmed, his body adorned with a plain black suit and tie.

He looked nice. Adora would've made fun of him for not showing his stomach.

Bow walked out of his room, his footsteps echoing through the silent corridor. His hands stayed in his pockets and he tried to avoid thinking too much about the day's activities.

As he was walking, Bow noticed Glimmer's door open a crack, causing him to pause. He could hear faint sniffling from the room. Checking his watch, he noted that the funeral was supposed to start in less than fifteen minutes. Concerned, he went to Glimmer's door and looked inside.

Glimmer was sitting against the wall, curled into a ball and completely unaware of Bow's presence. She looked disheveled, like she hadn't slept at all, and she was still wearing the same clothes she had been in when she was rescued.

"Glimmer?" Bow asked, feeling guilty to have intruded. "Are you alright?"

She didn't answer, just buried her face deeper in her arms.

Bow sat down next to her, speaking softly. "The funeral's going to start soon. Do you want to-"

"I'm not going," Glimmer said, her words muffled in her arms.

Bow frowned. "Glimmer, you have to."

Glimmer looked up at him. "H-How can I?" Standing up, Glimmer walked to her window, tears still falling silently. Bow followed. He didn't ask for more, knowing Glimmer would talk to him in her own time.

Sure enough, Glimmer was able to subdue her tears long enough to look at him. "I don't deserve to be there."

Bow put a hand on her shoulder, squeezing it reassuringly. "That's not true."

"Of course it is! This is all my fault. Adora's dead because of me a-and she died thinking I hate her," Glimmer cried harder. "I'll never

be able to make things right."

Bow pulled Glimmer into a hug, letting her cry it out. Rubbing her back, he whispered some reassuring words to her, waiting for her to calm down. When she finally pulled away, Bow kept both hands on her shoulders and looked her in the eyes.

"What happened isn't your fault, ok?" Bow said firmly. "You were being manipulated. Light Hope was always going to find a way to activate the Heart. That's not on you." He smiled sadly. "And she didn't hate you. She didn't think you hated her. You have to know that."

"I just want her to know I'm sorry."

"I'm sure she already does," Bow wiped away some of his own tears building up. "And she wouldn't want you to miss this."

Glimmer nodded, taking in his words. Deep down, she knew he was right. She just wished she could hear those words from someone else.

Going to her wardrobe to get dressed, Glimmer tried to stifle the rest of her sobs. It was pointless and she'd start crying again soon enough, but she figured she might as well try to pull herself together.

She put on a simple black dress, combed her hair back and wiped the ruined makeup from her face. She didn't reapply anything, not having the time nor motivation to. Returning to Bow, who had promised to wait for her, the two walked to where the funeral would take place. Glimmer held onto Bow's hand tightly, borrowing some strength from him to keep herself from dissolving, not knowing Bow was doing the same.

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As the princesses made their way to the outside garden in which the ceremony would take place, the brightness of the day paired

with the cool breeze made for a pleasant afternoon. Strange, considering the occasion.

The casket was at the end of the pathway, placed before a few chairs lined around it. Flowers were everywhere, courtesy of Perfuma, making the area smell sweet and inviting. The casket itself was decorated with blue flowers matching the shade of Adora's eyes.

A few sat down, while others stood in groups and talked quietly to one another. Bow and Glimmer were the last to arrive, sitting next to Micah at the front.

"I wish I had gotten to know her better," Micah said, the others nodding in agreement.

Glimmer looked around until she found the person she was most interested in: Catra.

By herself, she stood away from the main crowd, watching everything with a steady expression. She didn't have any red eyes, nor did she even look upset. To Glimmer's surprise, she was keeping unexpectedly cool given the circumstances. She was about to go over to her when she saw Scorpia walk over instead. Turning away, she decided not to intervene.

"Hey wildcat," Scorpia greeted calmly. "How are you holding up?"

Catra was going to ignore her, but realized that'd be wrong and offered a shrug instead. "I'm fine."

"Are you sure?" Scorpia asked worriedly.

"What do you want me to say Scorpia?" Catra asked bitterly.

"I don't know," Scorpia admitted. "I just thought you'd be a little more...emotional is all."

"It's just a funeral," Catra crossed her arms against her chest. "It's not that big of a deal. Just leave it at that, alright?" Seeing the

expression on Scorpia's face, she added hesitantly, "I just don't see the point in talking about this right now."

Scorpia sighed. She understood but at the same time, she just wished Catra would open up about everything. Bottling something like this up couldn't be healthy, but the fact that Catra was saying anything at all to her seemed like a step in the right direction.

The time came for people to speak. Bow and Glimmer went first, taking turns talking when the other was having trouble. They shared stories, adventures, regrets. There were times when they laughed and times when they cried.

Swift Wind went next, his colors dimmer than usual. It was probably the first time he had gone talking about something other than himself for such a long time period. As he was talking, Catra scanned the crowd.

Mermista and Sea Hawk were holding hands, though they were trying to in secret. He was blubbering like a baby, whereas Mermista was dry-eyed but gripping onto Sea Hawk all the same. Perfuma, Entrapta and Frosta sat a few seats over, feeling just as despondent. Scorpia stood next to her, which was nice. She appreciated the company despite the fact that she had tried to isolate herself earlier. Catra was glad to see that Shadow Weaver wasn't invited, nor had she made any unplanned entrances.

There was just one anomaly. Catra couldn't help but stare at the person directly across from them, standing away from the crowd as well, still and unmoved.

"Who invited 6-32?" Catra whispered to Scorpia, watching him suspiciously.

"He asked Bow if he could come I think," Scorpia said. "Why?"

"He didn't even know her," Catra said. "Just seems weird." As though he heard her, the guard turned to look at Catra, unnerving her further. Despite his help so far, she didn't trust him yet.

Looking away, she saw that Lonnie was speaking now. Kyle and Rogelio watched encouragingly from their seats. Catra watched in wonder at how naturally they seemed to fit in with the rebellion now. She wondered if Adora had become so comfortable so fast as well.

Her mind wandered back to the day Adora left. She still vividly remembered the hurt she felt. Maybe if she had stayed long enough to talk things out the right way, not leaving all that time for resentment to build up, maybe things could've gone differently.

Scorpia nudged Catra, causing the latter to realize that people were looking at her.

"Did you want to say anything?" Scorpia asked her quietly, likely repeating what had already been asked when Catra wasn't paying attention.

Not enjoying being put on the spot, Catra looked down at the ground, making it clear she didn't have anything to say.

With that, the ceremony came to a close soon after. Everyone watched as the casket was lowered into the ground. The dirt was shoveled on top of it, and just like that Adora disappeared. All that was left of her was the gravestone, which to Catra looked so out of place in such a beautiful garden.

How could any world be beautiful without Adora in it?

As the sun got lower in the sky, people left. There was a reception in the banquet hall where people could mingle and eat. Still, a few hung around for a while longer. Eventually, there was only two left.

Glimmer stood next to Catra, both staring down at the grave.

"Hey," Glimmer said, breaking the silence.

Catra looked over at her, unsure of where this conversation would be heading. If the princess really thought she was about to get

her to open up, she would be deeply mistaken.

"Relax," Glimmer said. "I just wanted you to have this." Holding out her hand, she gave Catra an envelope with her name written on it.

"What is it?" Catra asked.

"A letter from Adora." Glimmer looked up at the sky, feeling strange talking about Adora while looking at her tombstone. "I think she would want you to have it."

Catra didn't take her eyes away from the letter.

"Thank you," Catra said quietly, not sure if Glimmer heard her or not.

Smiling sadly, Glimmer walked away. It was probably best she left Catra alone.

Even If We Could

Chapter Summary

Catra reads Adora’s letter.

Catra stood in front of the grave for a long time. Hours passed until it was dark, though she hardly noticed. Hands at her sides, one clutched the unopened letter Glimmer gave her, the other stayed balled into a fist, nails digging into her palm.

The gray marble shined in the starlight, reflecting the heavens above. Entrapta had specially made it so the engravings would light up a cool blue in the darkness.

Adora. Savior of Etheria.

The dirt was still fresh.

Looking down at the letter, Catra couldn't open it. Her hands gripped the paper but did nothing more. With a shaky breath, Catra looked out into the forest which laid just beyond the gravesite.

"This isn't funny," Catra said softly. Upon the lack of response, she shouted, "You hear me? This isn't funny anymore, alright?"

Catra shook her head in frustration. "I know you want to get back at me but...but this is a messed up way to do it!" Staring into the black abyss of the trees, she almost expected an answer.

"Getting everyone in Brightmoon in on this was one thing," Catra continued to shout. "I almost bought it. But the games over, ok? Just, just come out already."

Nothing.

Catra screamed even though her throat was raw. "I'm serious Adora! If you don't I'll...I'll..." Catra's eyes landed on the letter

crumpled in her hands. "I'll read your stupid thing!" Her voice cracked and her whole body shook. "I'll read it and then there's no going back. So you, you better do something or...or..."

Silence.

Catra's shoulders drooped. The forest was just...silent.

"F-Fine then," Catra ripped open the letter. "It's probably stupid anyways."

The paper was folded in three. A note attached to the top read: *I will never send this. But it feels good to write it down.*

Swallowing, Catra unfolded the paper to see Adora's neat handwriting filling the page.

Dear Catra,
You are my enemy now, and you always will be. I know that now.

Catra couldn't help but see the irony. If only Adora could see her now, staying in Brightmoon, fighting with the rebellion instead of against them. She'd never hear the end of it.

All this time, I had hope. Hope that you would see the light. Hope that you would realize that Etheria is a beautiful place that needs to be saved, and not destroyed.

It's not that Catra had made a total change of heart. She still didn't know why the rebellion insisted on fighting wars they couldn't win, and Catra was pretty certain she'd die helping them. It probably wasn't close enough to what Adora had in mind. But if Adora really had sacrificed everything for this useless planet, it had to mean something, right?

I have no more hope now, and that makes me sad. So sad.

She wished she hadn't opened the letter. It's not like Catra didn't know Adora hated her. It's not like Catra didn't know she'd screwed up and had lost the only person in her life who cared.

Because I miss you, Catra, and I will always miss you.

It's not like Catra didn't miss Adora too.

Breathing became ragged. Catra was having a hard time reading, vision blurring.

I miss your smile. I miss the gleam in your eye when you would beat me in a race during training. I miss laughing with you when we would play a prank on one of the other cadets in the barracks. I even miss you snoring in the bunk above me.

Catra sank to her knees, tears falling freely now. Her mind was a thousand places. Memories that she'd never get to relive were just as bad as the memories Catra would never get to make again.

Those are the things I remember when I think about you. I'm going to try to remember the good things about you, instead of the bad ones. Because those break my heart.

Catra let go of the paper, her hands instead making their way to her face to silence her sobs. This couldn't be real. These couldn't be the last words Catra would ever get from her.

The paper fluttered to the base of the gravestone, waiting patiently for her. Catra glanced at it, only to see her own reflection looking back at her from the polished stone. The word "Adora" shone over her heart.

Unsteadily, Catra took the note again. Her eyes were trained on the paper, but it took her a moment to remember how to register the words.

I'm sorry things ended up like this. I really am. But even if we could go back in time, I wouldn't do things any other way.
Love, Adora

There was nothing else. It ended, just like that. Catra's thumb brushed those last words. *Love, Adora.*

Catra stood up. Her pants were now caked with mud. The tears were still falling, but she was regaining her breath. Her heart wasn't feeling like it would burst anymore.

"So," Catra asked hoarsely, "This is real then?"

The abyss didn't answer back.

"You know, I dedicated everything to beating you, and now you're...it's not fair," Catra sniffed weakly. "It wasn't suppose to end like this. We were always suppose to figure things out, eventually."

Brokenly, Catra whispered, "I should've gone with you. I should've but I was angry and I...why didn't I go with you?" The frustration built up pressure in her chest and Catra just needed to scream again. "Why did we have to be the ones with the fucked up childhoods? Why couldn't we live our lives?"

Catra was holding onto herself but she wished she was holding someone else.

"Why did we waste so much time?"

Catra's frowned at her own words. It was a ridiculous thought, something that had merely fluttered through her mind haphazardly, but suddenly she couldn't get it out of her head.

Catra skimmed through the letter again. She read aloud, "But even if we could go back in time...I wouldn't do things any other way."

Of course, Catra thought. Maybe she was insane. Maybe she was desperate. Or, maybe, she was right.

Clutching the letter, Catra stared at the gravestone, not in sadness anymore but hope.

"Adora, you genius," Catra laughed through her tears. "You brilliant stupid genius." Leaning down, she placed a hand on the

stone. "I'm going to make this right."

Catra walked away, then ran, then sprinted towards the castle. She had to tell the others everything.

They were going to save Adora.

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Just as Catra expected, everyone was still gathered in the reception, sat down at the large table and chatting idly. Seeing her rush in, muddy and red-eyed, a lot of people were staring but she didn't care. Catra needed their attention anyways.

She walked right up to Glimmer who was sitting at the head of the table and slapped the note down in front of her.

"Catra? What's going on?" Glimmer looked concerned. Catra knew she looked insane and that the next thing she said would likely solidify that idea.

"We need to open another portal."

The room erupted in cries of outrage. Catra paid no attention. She knew they'd react this way but if she could get them to see what she knew was possible, everything would be ok. That, or she'd be locked up in Brightmoon's prison. Does Brightmoon have a prison?

Glimmer held up her hand, shouting at everyone to quiet down before addressing Catra. "Why would we do that?"

"The planet's balanced, right?" Catra explained. "We don't have to worry about the universe collapsing in on itself anymore."

"Just because we can, doesn't mean we should," Glimmer said quietly.

"You aren't getting it," Catra shook her head. "I'm trying to save Adora."

"Adora's dead," Bow said. "Opening a portal won't change that."

"But it can," Catra insisted. "Look, when I opened the first one-" Catra noted the dirty looks she got for that, "-there was this moment when I fell into the void, and I somehow...I don't know, merged with the portal's magic.

"Semi-apodictic cellular rewrittance," Entrapta said, causing everyone to turn to her. "It's a phenomenon that I had studied within the portal's reality. If I had to make a hypothesis, when Catra only partially fell out of existence, the dark matter holding together her body was pure energy supplied from the portal."

Catra smiled, surprised to have Entrapta on her side. She walked over to her, continuing her rant. "Yeah, whatever that is. I was able to use it to my advantage. Change where I was at."

"You were able to manipulate space-time," Entrapta nodded.

"Exactly!" Catra said, looking to everyone as if they should've figured it out by now. Groaning, she explained further. "It wasn't just space I was manipulating. It was time."

"Oh!" Entrapta stood up excitedly, "You think we can use a portal to open a point in time. But that's purely theoretical science-"

"I know it'll work," Catra said. "That portal has haunted me every night since it was opened. I can't forget what it felt like if I tried, and it felt like time was everywhere, happening all at once. What if we could control how we move through it?"

"It's too dangerous," Glimmer said. "Every time someone's opened a portal, bad things have happened."

"This is Adora's life we're talking about," Catra slammed her hand on the table. "We could stop all of this from ever happening."

"Well, that depends on whether our timeline is fixed or not," Entrapta pointed out. "This all boils down to if time can be changed."

"It can't."

Everyone looked to the new speaker. 6-32.

"How would you know?" Glimmer asked.

"I've seen it attempted before," The guard said. "People thinking they can change the future. It always fails. Fate can't be changed."

"Adora didn't believe that," Catra said shakily. She clenched her fists so tight that her nails drew blood. She didn't want to cry in front of everyone.

Looking around the table, Catra knew they were all skeptical. The only one she had on her side was Entrapta, and even she seemed doubtful.

Catra's hopes were slowly sinking. "I know what it sounds like. But if there's even a chance...don't you guys want to take it?"

Bow stood up and walked over to Catra. "I'm in."

Entrapta joined them next. "If you give me a month, maybe two, I think we could make a viable machine."

Scorpia stood up, along with Lonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle. "I trust Catra," Scorpia said, to which the others agreed.

One by one the princesses joined, until the only ones sitting were Glimmer and 6-32.

"Your highness?" Catra asked.

Glimmer felt a headache coming on. She didn't like portals. She didn't think this was a good idea. But if there was even a slight possibility that she could see Adora again, she knew she had to take it.

"I'm in," Glimmer said. She walked to Catra's side of the room, leaving only one left.

"Can we count on you to help us?" Catra asked. "Because if not, you're free to leave."

The guard sat there for a moment, expression unreadable behind the helmet. Finally, he let out a long sigh. "I stand by what I said. I don't think you can change anything." Getting up, he continued, "That doesn't mean I won't help. Anything you need, just let me know."

If someone had told Catra that the day would end with her beaming, she wouldn't of believed them. Looking around at the people standing beside her though, she couldn't help it.

"Let's get Adora back."

Just a Memory

Chapter Summary

> The plan to save Adora is underway but in order to secure her future, the rebellion first must face her past.

Only a week had passed since the time travel idea had surfaced, but to many in the rebellion it felt like the longest week of their lives.

Entrapta and Bow had been working nonstop at building the portal. While Entrapta already knew how to make one, she still wasn't sure how to manipulate the *when* instead of the *where.*

The princesses had made it their job to make sure that Bow and Entrapta were eating and sleeping, seeing as if they didn't check on them, the two would never leave their work.

Meanwhile Glimmer and Catra were working tirelessly alongside 6-32, who helped smuggle information. Together, they were able to send teams out to minimize damage from Prime's patrols and wild Horde soldiers who were causing anarchy without a leader.

It seems Prime was toying with them. After all, he had the full power to wipe out the planet with his armies if he wanted to, but 6-32 insisted that he was only bidding his time, assessing the planet's power and how he wants to use it.

Today was different than most, however. Entrapta had told Bow that she needed more parts: first ones technology to be specific.

"I've sent out my bots to find matching energy signatures," Entrapta showed him her holopad, tracing a circle around the higher concentrations. "Right here is where we can maximize the most potential. If we could get a team to salvage what we can, it could move this along a lot faster."

Bow's stomach dropped. "That isn't just any first ones ruin. That's the Crystal Castle."

"If we want to make any progress, it has to be there," Entrapta insisted. "It's the only place with this powerful of readings."

Bow thought on it. Truthfully, he hadn't planned on ever going there again, but if Entrapta really thought it'd make a difference, he supposed he'd have to try.

"Alright," Bow reluctantly agreed. "I'll take a few people with me."

"Oh and Bow! One more thing," Entrapta said.

"Yeah?"

"It's about the castle. You see when I sent my bots there, they were picking up a lot of activity."

"You mean the castle is still active?" Bow's voice cracked. "It's destroyed though."

"I can't argue with the science," Entrapta shrugged. "The energy readings are high for a reason. Something is definitely still awake in that castle."

Great, Bow thought. *Just what we need.*

Leaving, he went directly to the meeting room, where he knew Glimmer would be. Sure enough, Glimmer was there, examining intel from one of their latest missions. Catra was there too helping her out.

"Hey," Bow said. "Can I borrow you two for a mission?"

"Depends," Catra said. "We already got a lot of people out today."

Bow explained the situation. They needed those parts as soon as possible if they wanted to make any real progress on the machine.

"I don't know," Catra said. "That place is dangerous. Last time I was there, things got bad really, really fast."

"It can't be that bad," Glimmer argued. "The place is broken down, right?"

"Did you not listen to him?" Catra argued back. "He just said that its still active."

"It's probably just old systems," Glimmer reasoned. "Right Bow?"

"I don't know," Bow answered honestly. "But when I was there last, I didn't think anything could still be working."

"Exactly," Glimmer said. Catra still didn't seem convinced. "Come on, it'll be quick. In and out."

"Fine," Catra huffed. "Let me just get my things."

"Put on some shoes!" Glimmer yelled at her as she walked away.

"Bite me!" Catra hissed back, disappearing down the hallway.

Glimmer shook her head playfully and turned to Bow who was giving her a strange look.

"What?" Glimmer asked.

"Nothing," Bow shrugged. "You two have just gotten a lot more friendly than I expected. It's a little weird is all."

"You weren't up there in that cell," Glimmer defended. "She's not the person we thought she was, or at least she's trying not to be that person anymore."

"I guess so," Bow admitted. "I bet Adora would lose it if she saw you two getting along."

"Yeah, she would." Glimmer smiled reminiscently, "We've come a long way since Dryl."

"What are you two just standing around for?" Catra walked back into the room, bag now slung over her shoulder. "Are we leaving or what?"

The three left the castle and began towards the one place they were all hoping they'd never see again.

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"We're close," Bow said as the path became less dirt and more scattered rubble. "Maybe a few minutes now."

Catra and Glimmer both felt uneasy about this trip, but for entirely different reasons.

For Catra, she hadn't been to the castle since her and Adora parted ways for good. There were a lot of bad memories tied to that place, literally. She didn't want to go through any of that again, nor did she want to think about that day in general. With growing resentment, Catra was almost certain that day was what pushed her over the edge.

Glimmer, on the other hand, couldn't stop thinking about the last time she'd been there. She had gone to Light Hope to activate the Heart of Etheria and she paid the price for it. Part of her was happy to see the place destroyed. The other part of her wished she didn't have to see it at all. It was just a reminder of the worst mistake of her life.

The pathway opened up to a clearing, where what remained of the Crystal Castle jutted out of the ground. The door was nearly closed, stuck in the frame.

"Here goes nothing," Bow mumbled. Gripping the door, he forced it open enough for the three to squeeze through.

At first they couldn't see anything. Weird because, Bow could've sworn there was a gaping hole in the roof when they were outside.

"I got it," Catra said. Reaching into her bag, she took out a flashlight.

"You just have that with you?" Glimmer asked.

"Unlike some people, I don't have glowing pink hands, so yeah, of course I brought a flashlight. I like to be prepared. See, this is why you guys keep getting conquered."

"Will you just turn it on already?" Glimmer groaned.

"Whatever." Catra clicked on the light, illuminating the room.

It looked just like Bow remembered. Debris filled the floor, making it impossible to walk a few steps without running into broken glass or giant slabs of concrete. Each footstep left behind an indent in the dust caking the floor.

The only area that was free of any wreckage was in the center of the room. The dust formed a perfect circle, untouched. Inside it, however, was dried red blood and the rest of the scattered pieces of the sword.

"That's where it happened," Glimmer said out loud. She couldn't take her eyes away from it.

"Hey," Catra nudged her gently. "If we get what we need here, we can make sure it never happens at all."

"Guys, I'm getting some weird interference on my holopad," Bow frowned at the device. "I don't know what we're suppose to be looking for without a proper reading of the energy signatures."

"Then we should just take anything that looks fancy," Catra said. "Something's bound to work, right?"

The three set to work, combing the room for anything advanced looking. Catra went with her flashlight, while Bow and Glimmer stayed together (Glimmer lighting the way with her magic).

Catra was able to toss a few things in her bag, though she had no idea what anyone was suppose to do with the scrap metal she was picking up. She tried to ignore the center of the room as much as she could.

"Did you have to?"

Catra spun around. Someone had said something right behind her it sounded like, but when she looked, Bow and Glimmer were all the way across the room.

Weird, Catra thought. Trying to push it aside, she went back to scavenging when she heard it again.

"Did you have to?" The voice repeated. "Did you have to?"

Now Catra was sure something was wrong. She turned to call out for Glimmer and Bow but found two others in their place.

"Did you have to make her so mean?"

"Is the one you call Catra not mean?"

Catra stared at the sight before her. She knew it was fake but then again...they looked so real.

Adora stood frozen next to Light Hope, pouting like a little kid. Catra walked up to her, tempted to say something, to reach out and touch her but she stopped herself.

The memory glitched, resetting the moment. "Did you have to make her so mean- so mean?"

"Is the one you call Catra not mean?"

"No, she is," Adora looked down sadly. Catra wondered how long ago this must of been.

"Catra?" Glimmer's voice sounded far away. "What is this?"

Catra looked around until she saw Glimmer, standing with Bow a few meters away from the hologram. They were both staring at the scene in bewilderment. Catra joined them, never taking her eyes off Adora.

"This place has a way to store memories," Catra explained. "Adora and I got trapped here before. Long story short, it sucked."

"Admit it!"

Catra jumped as Adora materialized beside her. Despite being fake, Catra felt it when Adora punched her in the arm. "Admit it! You like me."

"I don't like you," Catra said reflexively, before realizing what the castle was trying to make her do. Shaking her head, she stepped away, not wanting to get trapped in her head again.

"This is...so weird," Bow said. "It does explain why there's so much activity here though."

"Yeah, well just don't get too caught up in it," Catra said. "Adora's not really here. It's just this place malfunctioning. Let's finish what we came for."

They went to walk away when a hand pulled Glimmer back. She turned around and was face to face with an angry Adora.

"This is a waste of time Glimmer," She insisted.

Not real, Glimmer told herself, though she could still feel where Adora touched her. *Not real.*

"I'm not whining!" Adora shouted, unprompted. Glimmer was beginning to remember this conversation. She didn't like where this was going.

"All you do is question me," Glimmer said to herself. "Question my authority."

"Hey," Catra went to her, trying to pull her out of it. "Come on. Ignore it."

"Look at what she's doing!" Adora said, causing Catra to hesitate before remembering this didn't have anything to do with her. "Look at what she's doing to you! Shadow Weaver just wants power and you're listening to her."

"Glimmer snap out of it."

Glimmer found herself shaking Catra's hand loose. "Oh, what? Are you jealous because you aren't Shadow Weaver's favorite anymore?" Even as she said it, she knew she was wrong.

Bow had joined Catra, trying to disrupt the memory but this Adora seemed more persistent than the rest.

"You stopped including me in your decisions! We used to be a team. And now? I don't know what we are."

Catra decided she'd have to take brash action. Grabbing a taser from her bag, she tackled the hologram, tumbling on the ground. When she got up, she saw Adora slid away, not on the ground but off a cliff. Instead of a taser in her hand, there was a sword.

"Every hero needs a sidekick."

Catra hadn't said anything. Instead the words floated through the air, deafening.

"Every hero needs-every hero-" The cavern was breaking down around them. Catra dropped the sword, stumbling backwards to the others.

"We need to get out of here," Bow insisted. "Come on!"

The three ran in the direction they thought the entrance was, though they couldn't be sure. Glimmer tried to teleport them away, but the emotional distress paired with the fact that she still

hadn't recovered completely from the ship, meant there was no way she could get all three of them out of there at once.

"You aren't listening to me! Don't I get a say in what happens to me?" The cavern rumbled around them. "Don't I get a choice?"

Don't think into it, they all thought. *It wasn't real. It wasn't-*

Glimmer, Bow, and Catra ran face first into a barrier. Disoriented at first, they all paled when they saw what they were about to watch.

"No," Bow said quietly. "Not this one."

She-Ra stood in the center of the room, power coursing through her. She was shouting, desperately trying to push her sword to the ground.

"Is this-" Catra asked, before pounding on the force field. "Wait! No!"

"I can't watch," Glimmer buried her face in Bow's shoulder, Bow watching helplessly.

"Do it."

Adora's face changed in that moment. The pain in her features lifted and the three could see a look of tired resignation. With her final bit of strength, they watched as Adora plunged the sword to the ground.

The sword shattered, sending pieces of metal flying out through the room: including the parts that were sent into Adora's abdomen.

They watched as Adora fell to the ground and held their breath as Adora's head lulled to the side. She was looking right at them. If they didn't know any better, they almost thought Adora could see them.

The force field fell. They rushed to her side but when Bow reached for her, Adora dissolved in his hands.

"Did you know that First Ones take approximately three times longer to bleed out than an Etherian? It leads to quite a long, painful death."

They looked up to see Light Hope staring down at them, except she was glitching and distorted.

"You did this," Glimmer charged at the hologram but went right through her.

"Adora chose to destroy the sword," Light Hope continued unbothered. "All of her potential was wasted. Truly, she is my biggest disappointment."

"I'll end you," Catra growled. She stood up, searching for her taser.

"No," Light Hope said. "I will end you. Leave this place and do not return."

"Not going to happen," Bow glared. "Not until we get what we need. You wouldn't happen to be able to point us in the right direction, would you?"

"So you have chosen death," Light Hope flickered. "So be it."

Emerging from Light Hope came another hologram, this one being She-Ra again — except this version was covered in red veins and had an animalistic look in her eyes.

"Oh no," Bow squeaked. He jumped out of the way as Adora swung her sword wildly at him.

"Get the sword!" Glimmer shouted. She attempted to teleport onto She-Ra's shoulders but didn't stick the landing, instead slamming into Adora's back.

The hologram turned around to attack her when Catra appeared, taser meeting sword. She gritted her teeth as she held the sword back, knowing if she slipped that she'd be cut in two.

Bow notched an arrow and shot at Adora's hands. It hit the sword, sending the weapon flying away into the darkness.

"Ok. Maybe it's time to leave after all," Bow shouted. The three agreed, racing to the exit. Once Bow and Glimmer were through, Catra turned to look back. Light Hope was standing in the center of the room.

Pulling out a small round object from her bag, Catra tossed it right at her. "This one's for Adora!"

Catra jumped out of the room, just in time for the entire castle to explode. The three watched out of breath as the structure fell in on itself.

"You brought a grenade?!" Glimmer yelled exasperatedly. "What if that went off in your bag?!"

"It didn't," Catra shrugged.

"There goes our tech," Bow said dismayed.

"I mean, we have a few things," Catra said. "It's got to be enough, right?"

Bow nodded, staring at his holopad. Without the tower disrupting it, he could get a clear reading. "I still can't shake that there was something else there we were meant to get but whatever was giving off that power signature is gone now."

"Look, let's just head back," Glimmer said. "That was...way too much to process."

"Agreed," Catra said. The three began back towards the castle, sharing what they had found and discussing what they should do next.

None were aware of the person watching them leave.

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"You did good. Definitely had me convinced. Don't you think it was a little harsh though?"

"I only did what you asked me to do," Light Hope said.

Light Hope and 6-32 stood behind the castle, watching it crumble to pieces. It truly was going to be gone for good, meaning the hologram didn't have much time.

"I only asked you to scare them away," 6-32 said. "I didn't think you'd do all of that."

"You wanted them to destroy the castle. I gave them a reason to. And did you get what you wanted?"

6-32 examined the object in his hands. He had waited a long time to find this. After everything he'd gone through to get to this point, he didn't think he'd ever see She-Ra's sword again.

"It's been a long time since you've held that," Light Hope said.

"Time is funny like that," He remarked, filled with wonder.

"I hope all of this sneaking around with the princesses hasn't distracted you from your real goal."

"Believe me, I always have that in mind," 6-32 said. "It's hard to forget."

"Do you truly believe you can see your plan through?" Light Hope asked. Her form wavered. It was about to give out completely.

"I hope so," 6-32 watched as Light Hope flickered out of existence forever. "Or we killed She-Ra for nothing."

The Masks We Wear

Chapter Summary

> Frustrations grow as distrust begins to fester in the rebellion. 6-32 gets an ultimatum.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Though it wasn't much, Entrapta was able to reassure the others that she could make do with what they brought back. It wasn't up to her expectations, but it was better than nothing. They'd simply have to go on more similar runs to make up for it, although they would steer clear of the Crystal Castle from there on out.

Bow had taken charge of leading the expeditions, taking teams out to retrieve whatever they could find from various ruins. Between those and the skirmishes with Prime's foot soldiers, the rebellion was spread thin.

Catra spent most of her time in the castle, making plans, choosing who to send where. Glimmer had opted to go out and fight, happy to hand her responsibilities over to someone else. She was better in the field anyways.

Then, there was 6-32.

Much to Catra's annoyance, he wasn't able to offer a lot. Not only did he refuse to fight, but the information he brought back was becoming less and less useful.

"You're late," Catra said upon hearing the door open, not looking up from her work.

"I apologize," 6-32 said. "It's not exactly like I can work Prime's schedule around you all."

"Yeah well it's like the fifth time you've been late," Catra complained. "If you can't make it, change the time you agree to meet up."

6-32 grumbled to himself. "It's not easy going back and forth you know. And with the rumors going around-"

"Rumors?"

"Talk on the ship is that there's a traitor among us."

"Well, they're right." Catra turned to 6-32, crossing her arms. "Do they think it's you?"

"No," He shook his head. "They're thinking it's someone higher in the ranks. I've been able to slip by under the radar but it's only a matter of time."

"Is that all you have for me?" Catra asked impatiently. "We need to know what Prime is doing next, where he'll send his troops. We're barely holding them back as it is."

"If I knew I would tell you," 6-32 said slowly as though he were talking to a child. "I don't get my information from Prime himself. I have to ask around. With the witch hunt up there, there's not a lot I can do."

Catra wasn't happy with it but had to accept that was the best she'd get.

"One more thing," 6-32 said, getting ready to leave. "I'm concerned that there might be bugs planted nearby. I'll be looking for them if you need me. Until then, try not to use my name much."

"Says the guy who doesn't have a name." Catra watched as he left. Sighing she was ready to get back to her paperwork when Glimmer walked in.

"Another lovely meeting I suppose?" Glimmer asked.

"It was great," Catra responded sarcastically. "I'm so glad we have him here."

"Well you should be," Glimmer sighed. "If it weren't for him, we would've been overrun by now. Frosta and I were able to take out a good sized group near her kingdom. Are Mermista and Perfuma back yet?"

"No."

"What about Sea Hawk and Bow? Heard anything from them?"

"They were having complications but haven't sent any distress calls. I'm sure they're fine." Catra sat down, staring at the table dejectedly.

"What's wrong?" Glimmer sat down across from her.

"The guard," Catra said. "I don't know, something's just off to me. I feel like he's hiding something."

A new voice entered the conversation "That's probably because he is."

"What do you want Shadow Weaver?" Catra glared.

"I told you this room was off limits," Glimmer said.

"I just couldn't help but overhear about your little problem," Shadow Weaver drawled. "It seems to me that for someone who is so desperate to see his brother defeated, he isn't putting much effort into it."

"Have you ever said anything nice about people behind their backs?" Catra asked. "Even once?"

"Do not be smart with me," Shadow Weaver warned. "I am merely trying to offer my help."

"We don't need it," Glimmer said. "You're lucky we even let you stay in this castle."

Shadow Weaver hummed, gliding towards the door. "Yes, well, if you're alright with entrusting a complete stranger again, be my guest. After all, it worked out so well for you last time."

Glimmer felt her face heat up and would've gone after her if Catra didn't give her a look.

"She's not worth it," Catra said. Admittedly, she did want to go after Shadow Weaver herself, but they had bigger things to deal with. "Don't let her get to you."

Glimmer didn't say anything, just sat down in the chair. "I mean maybe-"

"No," Catra pointed at her accusingly, "Nope. No. Don't start."

"What if she has a point?" Glimmer asked. "I'm not saying she's right, but maybe we shouldn't be trusting this guy as much as we are."

"First of all, I don't trust him so let's make that clear."

"But we're letting him into Brightmoon and we don't even know him," Glimmer argued. "He hasn't done a lot for us, not really. I'd just like to know a little bit more about him."

Catra tapped her foot anxiously, her tail flicking side to side. "Fine. Let's just ask him to do something small, something to prove he's on our side once and for all."

"Like what?"

Catra thought for a second before an idea came to mind. "What about that helmet? Have you ever seen him take it off? He gets real touchy about it too. That's weird, right?"

"We could call a meeting," Glimmer said. "See what he does with all of us there."

They agreed to have one as soon as the others returned. It wouldn't be long and then they could put those doubts to rest. Because after all, if they found out they couldn't trust 6-32, then they were in for a world of trouble.

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"No, absolutely not."

"Why?" Glimmer demanded.

"Did Catra not care to enlighten you?" 6-32 motioned at the girl. "There's a high chance that Horde Prime could be listening, watching. If I showed you all my face, I could be executed."

"Sounds to me like you're just scared," Mermista said, picking at her nails.

6-32 turned to her. "Do they all need to be here?" He motioned to the entirety of the rebellion. "We couldn't of settled this like adults? You had to make a scene?"

"You're the one who's making this a bigger deal than it needs to be," Catra shrugged. "Just take off the helmet and show us that you trust us."

"Did you miss the part where that could kill me?"

"Our lives are always in danger," Bow said. "If you aren't willing to risk it then maybe you're not as righteous as you think you are."

"Believe me, I know all about risking lives," 6-32 snapped. "No. I'm sorry, but no, I'm not doing it."

He stood up, ready to leave.

Glimmer was losing him. She had to make a stand. "If you walk out that door, don't expect to walk back in unless you have that mask off."

6-32 stared at her in disbelief. "You'd trade an inside man just so that you don't have to sleep with one eye open?"

"Yes?" Glimmer didn't sound too sure.

"Yes," Catra reinforced it. "Consider it *my* test. For you."

Even though they couldn't see the face behind the mask, Catra had the strange sense that 6-32 was smiling.

"Fine," He relented. "Give me time to check the perimeter for any bugs and I'll do it. But it can't be with everyone here. Just Glimmer and Catra."

"No way," Frosta shot up and turned to Glimmer. "We get to see him, right?"

"Forgive me but I don't exactly trust the rest of you yet. It's those two, or no deal." He extended his hand.

Everyone looked to Glimmer to decide. Reluctantly she took his hand.

"Deal."

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As discussed, Glimmer, Catra, and 6-32 would be meeting in Glimmer's room once night fell.

"Where is she?" 6-32 asked impatiently.

"She'll be here," Glimmer assured him. "She's late."

What Glimmer wasn't telling him was that was entirely intentional. They figured it would give Glimmer some extra time to study him, which seemed like a good idea originally. As much as 6-32 tried to

be the suave and mysterious spy, he was...well, clumsy to say the least. He slipped up a lot, meaning this should of been a piece of cake.

Now though, alone together, Glimmer couldn't figure him out at all. Maybe it was the nerves but he was a lot more rigid than usual, a lot more soldierly. He just stood there watching the door in silence.

"So," Glimmer said attempting to spark conversation. "Did you actually find any bugs?"

"Yes actually," 6-32 said to her surprise.

"What?!"

"I disabled the ones I could find, if that's what you're worried about. I can't guarantee that I got all of them though. I'll be sending Entrapta one of them so she can examine it, maybe find the rest."

"Oh," Glimmer said. "That's actually very helpful of you." *So he wasn't making that up.*

"Hey," Catra entered the room. "Sorry I'm late. Entrapta wouldn't stop hounding me about the portal. Did I miss the big reveal?"

"Let's just get this over with shall we?" 6-32 said, to which Catra and Glimmer watched him anxiously.

Placing a hand to the side of his helmet, he pressed a button, unlocking the bottom of it. Sliding it carefully off of his head, both girls couldn't help but gasp.

He looked like how they'd expected, with one exception. Sure enough, he had the same face as the other clones they'd met, looking the most like the scientist — in more ways than one.

The left side of his face was horrifically scarred, though it looked like the wounds came from a long time ago. From his eyebrow to

the tip of his chin were long claw marks, his eye grey and unseeing.

"And now you see my shame," 6-32 said, sounding sadder than the others had ever heard him. "This is the real reason I didn't want you to see my face, or at least what's left of it."

"Y'know it's really not that bad," Catra lied. "I actually didn't even notice it until you pointed it out."

The guard didn't find that very amusing. Instead he sat down heavily on one of the cushiony chairs in the room. "Where I come from, imperfection is not tolerated. I wear this helmet not as a mask but as a punishment for my weakness."

Catra knew where he was coming from. She knew what it was like to grow up in a place where you couldn't act hurt, remembered the many injuries she would hide to spare herself the humiliation.

"May I?" 6-32 held the helmet back up. Glimmer nodded. Without time to waste, 6-32 slid the helmet back on, latching it in place.

"You know," Glimmer said guiltily. "Once we get rid of the rest of the bugs, you don't have to keep that on. No one here will judge you because of how you look."

"I will," 6-32 said sadly. "So...is that it? Are we on the same side again?"

"Yeah," Catra said, trying not to sound disappointed. "Yeah, I guess we are."

Leaving it at that, 6-32 was quick to leave. Still, something was bothering Catra. She just couldn't place a finger on it.

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6-32 sat just outside Brightmoon's perimeter anxiously scanning the area as he waited. His ship was ready to go rejoin Prime's. He was just waiting on one thing.

"No need to look so worried darling."

6-32 whipped around to see his double sauntering towards him.

"What took you so long?" 6-32 hissed. "I've been waiting for hours."

"Catra was late," His copy teased. "I'm sure you understand. Scheduling errors and all."

"Did they buy it or not?" 6-32 pressed.

"Relax," They laughed. Changing, the figure transformed from the guard to Double Trouble. "They heard the story they wanted to hear. Both of them are suckers for a good sob story so I knew it'd be a hit. Don't get me wrong, they're still wary of you, but they don't suspect the right things."

"Inspiring," 6-32 said sarcastically. He shoved his hand in his pockets, revealing a bag of money. "As promised."

"A pleasure doing business," Double Trouble took the bag, counting out it's contents. "I have to ask, why don't you really want them to see that beautiful face of your's under that ugly little mask?"

6-32 straightened up and walked to his ship. "They wouldn't like what they saw. People don't trust monsters."

"Trust?" Double Trouble laughed loudly. "Why bother with such a fickle thing as trust?"

"Easy," 6-32 leaned against the entry of the ship in contemplation. "I need them to trust me because when I finally betray them...it needs to hurt."

Chapter End Notes

Hey y'all! Sorry for the lack of updates, I had exams this week but with nanowrimo I'm hoping to get a lot of new stuff

out :)

That One Chapter Where Shadow Weaver Gets Everything She Deserves

Chapter Summary

"Go ahead. Prove me right."

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

About a week had passed since the intervention with 6-32 and the rebellion was happy to see morale improving.

Entrapta had indeed found a way to source out more spyware and sure enough there were some still around. While that did take up her time, she still was making good progress on the portal alongside Bow.

With the bugs being demolished, Catra found they also weren't being so easily overwhelmed, meaning Prime wasn't getting their intel anymore. She supposed she had 6-32 to thank for that.

Despite all of that, Catra found she had been working day and night. She didn't remember the last time she slept more than a few hours at a time. Maybe it had to do with keeping busy. Sleeping just ushered in more nightmares, or even worse, dreams of Adora. The pleasant ones were always the worst. *Some day*, she kept telling herself, *some day they can be real.*

The day had passed by slowly and when Scorpia got back from her mission with Lonnie and the others, the former made sure to check on Catra.

"Hey there," Scorpia greeted warmly. "How've you been?"

"Same as same," Catra yawned. She scribbled away at the battle plans in front of her, trying to decide what teams to send out tomorrow.

"You want to take a break?" Scorpia asked. "Me and the Horde crew were going to go down to the pools if you wanted to come."

"Uh, I don't know," Catra shrugged. "I still don't think they want to see me all that much."

"It was Lonnie's idea," Scorpia placed a claw on Catra's shoulder. "Everyone sees how hard you're working. You deserve a break."

"Prime isn't taking breaks," Catra said coldly. "We shouldn't be either."

Out of the corner of her eyes, Catra saw the disappointment on Scorpia's face.

"Wait, just..." Catra cursed herself. "Sorry I'm just tired is all. I didn't mean that."

"I get it," Scorpia nodded. "But you're also proving my point. Come on! This'll be good for you."

Catra still wasn't sure. She had a lot of work on her plate. Then again, she hadn't been to the Brightmoon pools yet. "Fine. Don't get used to it though."

"I'll meet you down there," Scorpia grinned. She headed out the room, beaming. Catra couldn't help but smile too. As pesky as Scorpia was, she had to admit she was happy to have a friend like her.

Catra stood up and stretched. She honestly didn't remember how long she had been sitting at that table, making her muscles stiff.

She decided to change before meeting the others, though she didn't really plan to swim. Growing up she'd always hated water and would avoid it at all costs. Still, knowing the ruffians she'd be joining, she was bound to get pushed in the pool one way or another.

"*You don't deserve to be friends with them again.*" The words echoed throughout the empty hallway.

Catra stopped in her tracks. That wasn't her inner voice, but it definitely sounded like her.

"*You don't deserve to be here. You're just one bad day away from turning into the monster you know you are. They're all just waiting for it to happen.*"

Catra was fairly certain she knew what was happening, which truthfully only made her dread this situation more.

"Shadow Weaver?" Catra called out angrily, careful not to give away any fear. "You realize I'm not stupid enough to fall for this, right?"

"It's not a trick," Shadow Weaver appeared behind Catra. "It's the truth."

"You wouldn't know the truth if it hit you in the face," Catra turned on her. "Which last I checked, I already did that for you."

"It seems you still haven't figured out how to quell your temper," Shadow Weaver mocked, trailing in circles around Catra. "You're just as weak as when I left you."

"My only weakness was thinking I could earn your respect," Catra followed her with her eyes, not daring to let the woman out of sight.

"Why bother with respect when you can have power?" Shadow Weaver stopped in front of Catra. "You were at the top and then you wasted it. You're a failure."

"I'm glad," Catra spat. "I'd rather be a failure then turn into you. And for the record, this isn't failing. This is me finally deciding to do something good for once."

"Oh, of course," Shadow Weaver laughed. "Your foolish plan to save Adora. Tell me, what do you think she'll say when you come running to her rescue? Do you really think she'll welcome you with open arms after everything you've done? Do you really expect her to forgive you?"

"I know she won't," Catra said. "It doesn't matter."

"What if I told you I could change that?" Shadow Weaver went to place a hand on Catra's cheek but Catra swatted it away. "What if I could give you an Adora who actually wanted you?"

Catra backed away, not considering for a moment that Shadow Weaver was being genuine. She put distance between the two but kept her fists ready for a fight.

Shadow Weaver waved her hand and the shadows seeped from the wall into a figure between the two. First came the blonde ponytail, then the red jacket. In a matter of seconds, Catra found herself face to face with Adora.

"Catra," Adora reached out a hand for her.

"Again, not falling for it," Catra began to walk away. "Try your tricks on someone who actually cares."

"Catra!" Adora's panicked voice made Catra turn instinctively despite her intentions to leave.

Adora was hunched over, clutching her stomach which was bleeding profusely. Her skin was pale and there was fear in her eyes. "Catra, please."

"Stop it," Catra growled.

"Why did you do this?" Adora tried to grab at her. "Why did you do this to me?"

Catra pushed past the illusion, lunging for Shadow Weaver. "Stop it or I'll make you!"

Shadow Weaver let Catra grab her by the collar of her clothes. Gripping onto the fabric, Catra was inches away from her tormentor.

"Now, now," Shadow Weaver tutted. "A good-hearted freedom fighter like yourself wouldn't hurt someone, would they?"

"You deserve it," Catra said through clenched teeth. "You deserve to be hurt." Catra raised her hand, claws out. One cut to the neck was all it would take. One hit that Shadow Weaver couldn't heal and she'd never have to live in fear again.

"C-Catra," Adora choked out from the floor. "Please...don't-t."

"You're a monster Catra," Shadow Weaver said. "It's what you do. Go ahead. Prove me right."

"Catra?" Someone said, except they weren't an illusion.

"Lonnie?" Catra looked behind her. "What are you-"

Catra didn't finish as Lonnie charged straight for her — and passed her, tackling Shadow Weaver to the ground. Catra fell down, watching in bewilderment.

"You better not be messing with our friend with your voodoo magic," Lonnie landed a punch on Shadow Weaver. As she did, the Adora illusion disappeared, the shadows dispersing back into the environment.

Catra saw Rogelio and Kyle enter too, obviously running behind Lonnie. Rogelio went immediately to Catra to check on her, while Kyle dragged Lonnie away.

"Who do you think you are?" Shadow Weaver gasped, a small cut on her forehead dripping blood. "You little pest!"

"If I see you anywhere near Catra again, I'll break more than just your face!" Lonnie shouted. Rogelio stood up to his full height too, walking towards Shadow Weaver threateningly. Kyle also tried to

look scary but he just couldn't pull it off so he tried not to bring too much attention to himself.

Taking the hint, Shadow Weaver slid back into the shadows. "You will all regret this. You will rue the day-"

Fed up, Catra grabbed one of the vases next to her and threw it at Shadow Weaver, who sadly disappeared before it shattered against the wall.

Panting, Lonnie went over to Catra who was staring at the group in utter confusion.

"What just happened?" Catra asked.

"We showed that crazy woman what's up is what happened," Lonnie punched Catra lightly on the shoulder. "She shouldn't be messing with you any time soon."

"Y-Yeah!" Kyle joined in. "Man, that was so cool! Lonnie was all 'imma get you' and ran into her like bang and then Catra was all 'take this' and-"

Rogelio held a hand up to cut him off, saying something along the lines of *please be quiet before you make this weird.*

"I guess I should thank you," Catra rubbed her arm ashamedly. "I probably would've done something pretty bad if you all didn't show up."

"And?" Lonnie made a face. "She deserves it."

Catra wasn't sure Lonnie was getting the point. "Yeah, but this place isn't the Horde. Shouldn't we be doing good or whatever?"

"Catra, that woman hasn't done any good her entire life. Believe me, she has it coming for her." Lonnie started dragging Catra away. "Now are we going to the pool or not?"

Catra looked over her shoulder, seeing nothing but an empty, well-lit hallway. Looking back at them she smiled.

"Yeah, let's go."

Chapter End Notes

> Shadow Weaver: “is it me? Am I the drama? I don’t think I’m the drama…”

The Secret Weapon

Chapter Summary

> Prime forces the rebellion’s hand but someone else may be pulling the strings.

"No, no, no!" Entrapta shouted, racing around her makeshift lab, flipping switches and hitting things with her wrench when they would spark.

Upon hearing all the noise, Bow, who had fallen asleep in the hallway, shot up and barreled into the room. "What's happening?"

"Get down!" Entrapta shouted, taking cover herself under one of the desks. Bow fell to his stomach, curled into a protective position and holding his head in his hands.

The portal in front of them was making a high pitched ringing sound, growing in frequency, and was sending sparks into the air. The middle of it was flickering at random.

"How do you turn that thing off?" Bow shouted over the noise.

"I think it'll do that itself!" She yelled back. Just as she did, the portal sent out a wave of energy, creating a loud boom, before shutting down.

Bow looked up, breathing heavily. His ears were ringing and he had the worst headache of his life but he was happy to see both him and Entrapta were unharmed.

"Time travel test seven...inconclusive," Entrapta said groggily into her recorder. "Portal could not withstand a complete jump."

Bow rubbed his ears, examining the lab. Luckily the portal frame itself hadn't been damaged but some of the surrounding parts and papers were singed from the heat of the blast.

"What was wrong this time?" Bow asked, not realizing he was shouting.

"I’m not sure," Entrapta responded just as loudly. "I thought the machine would've been able to handle the force of the time flow. When I pushed into the stream, the portal was fine, but it couldn't push through the barrier to the other side."

Bow nodded. He only really understood half of what Entrapta was saying. His brain had been so preoccupied with the mechanics of everything that he didn't have much time to ponder on the movement of time itself.

Through their research, and Catra's retelling of her experiences, they were able to find out that time was indeed all around them. The portal itself just acted as a gateway into the stream, opening a hole from one moment to another. They weren't controlling it so much as surfing it. The problem was just not getting drowned in the waves, these ones being made of pure light matter instead of water.

"Do you think we need a greater power source?" Bow tried to be helpful. "We have some expeditions scheduled tomorrow to scavenge a ruin near Alwyn. Maybe we can find something useful there."

"I don't need more technology," Entrapta said, tapping her wrench on the table distractedly. "I have more than enough. I just need a different perspective. Someone who's studied portals just as long as I have."

Bow figured out where this was going. "You don't mean Hordak."

"He was my lab partner," Entrapta defended. "He and I made more progress with inter-dimensional travel than I've been able to ever replicate."

"Maybe we can do something about that," Someone interjected. Bow turned to see 6-32 standing in the doorway.

"Do you think you could bring a message to Hordak?" Entrapta asked excitedly.

"It's possible..." 6-32 trailed off when he saw the look Bow was giving him. "Uh. Maybe. I mean, honestly I really don't know… actually."

Bow turned to Entrapta sincerely. "We'll figure something out but let's just consider all the options first, alright?"

Walking away, he pulled 6-32 into the hallway. "Can we talk for a moment?"

"We're talking right now."

"Yeah, ok," Bow tried not to look so annoyed. "Here's the thing. We can't bring Hordak here."

"Why not?" 6-32 asked. "The princess just said that she needs him to open the portal. Shouldn't we do anything that moves that along?"

"Yeah well Hordak also ran an evil empire that nearly destroyed everything we know and love, so I think we have a reason to not want him here."

6-32 seemed to understand, or at least he didn't show any resistance to that.

"So no Hordak?" Bow reiterated.

"No Hordak," 6-32 echoed. "Right."

Bow wasn't sure if he had gotten anywhere with him but he didn't have time to waste explaining it any further. Instead he went back to the lab to help Entrapta. Meanwhile 6-32 left, already knowing what he was going to do.

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It was the middle of the night, meaning most of the rebellion was asleep. The only ones awake were Catra, who was trying to sleep and failing, and Glimmer, who had no interest in sleeping at all. They sat in the garden, not talking but each enjoying the other's company, watching how the stars glistened on Adora's tombstone.

It was a peaceful night, quiet and cold. The only sounds in the air were the leaves rustling in the wind, the chirps of small bugs and birds, and the thunderous footsteps of a panicked Horde soldier running straight at them.

"What the-" Catra watched him approach in disbelief. "This better be good."

"Where are the other princesses?" 6-32 demanded as he ran. "Where?"

"They're in their rooms, sleeping," Glimmer said warily. "Why?"

"We need to move them," 6-32 stopped in front of the two, gasping for air. "Fast. You're all in danger."

Glimmer summoned her staff. "What kind of danger?"

"Horde Prime," 6-32 explained hurriedly in between breaths. "Ambush. Tonight. Plans to. To kidnap. Princesses. Weapon."

"The Heart of Etheria," Glimmer mumbled. She turned to Catra. "Go wake the others. Tell them to get ready for a fight."

"No!" 6-32 insisted. "No fighting. We can't win. You need to get them away from here. Far away. The less princesses Prime can take. The better."

"We aren't just going to run away," Catra said, already heading towards the castle.

"You should!" 6-32 shouted. "This isn't a fight you'll win!"

"We have to try," Catra said before running out of sight.

"She's right," Glimmer said. "If we don't stand our ground when they come for us, they'll take it as a sign of weakness."

"Dying is a pretty good sign of weakness," 6-32 got in Glimmer's face. "Unless you all want to end up like her-" He pointed to the grave, "-then I suggest you wisen up and pick your battles."

"Don't." Glimmer pushed the guard away roughly. "Don't lecture me on what wars to fight. If you don't want to be here, then leave."

6-32 stared at Glimmer before stomping away. "Fine!" He threw up his arms. "Give Prime exactly what he wants. Don't say I didn't warn you!"

Glimmer watched him leave. She didn't need him. And she wasn't going to back down. That still didn't get rid of that gut feeling in her stomach: the feeling that something very bad was about to happen very soon.

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"You must be crazy," Mermista stared at Catra as if she'd grown a third eye. "How exactly are we suppose to fight off Prime himself?"

"Scorpia, back me up here," Catra looked out to the rebellion gathered in front of her.

"I-I don't know Catra," Scorpia looked away ashamedly. "We're all worn pretty thin as it is. Is it really a good idea to fight a battle we won't win?"

"Who says we won't win?" Frosta countered. "I'm ready to kick Prime's butt for what he did to Glimmer."

"We've been holding our defenses well with the small troops he's bringing," Perfuma said. "But if he's planning a full attack on us, we don't stand a chance."

"Technically, 6-32 never mentioned a full blown attack," Catra pointed out. "And since when have you guys backed down from a fight?"

"We've never faced an army this large without She-Ra before," Perfuma said sheepishly.

"Seriously?" Catra scoffed. "Believe me, you all were handing it to the Horde way before She-Ra started helping you out."

"But it's Prime," Mermista argued. "His armies are huge compared to the Horde's. He's not crazy enough to come alone."

"Uh, guys," Bow spoke up. He had been watching out the windows, keeping an eye for any incoming troops. "I think that's exactly what he's doing."

The princesses all rushed to the windows to see a single ship descending near Brightmoon. Sure enough, Horde Prime was the only one, not counting two guards that followed him on either side.

Glimmer teleported into the room. "We need to go."

"None of the princesses should go down there yet," Entrapta said. "Or at least, none connected to a runestone. If he has us all, there's still a possibility that he could activate the heart of Etheria."

"Fine," Catra said. "Then just me, Bow, and Entrapta then."

"What about me?" Sea Hawk asked.

"You should stay here and...guard the princesses," Catra reasoned. "For safety purposes or something."

"I will protect them with my life!" Sea Hawk puffed his chest out.

"Right," Catra said, regretting every single decision she had ever made. Looking out the window, she could see Horde Prime

waiting, watching. "We need to go. We'll signal you all if we need to." They all nodded, hoping it wouldn't come to that.

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Catra, Bow and Entrapta stood outside the Brightmoon entrance as Horde Prime came closer and closer.

"You better stay there," Bow warned, arrow already in place. "We aren't afraid to shoot."

"Now, now," Prime held up his hands innocently. "I didn't come for a fight."

"I doubt that," Catra said. "If that's the case, why are you here?"

"I've been polite enough to give your little rebellion a few wins, but I think enough is enough. I'd like my super weapon now."

"You aren't getting it," Bow stared him down.

"I disagree," Prime smiled darkly. "I think you'll hand over everything I need."

"Why would we do that?" Bow asked.

"Because," Prime held up a hand, motioning to his war ship in the sky. "If you don't, I'll send every last one of my soldiers into your castle and reduce it to rubble. I'll even let you watch it all burn, before you're all left to die. I only need the princesses after all."

The three didn't falter. Prime talked big but the question was would he follow through.

"I'm not here to bargain," Prime continued. "You will give me the princesses or I will destroy everything you hold dear."

"You'll do that anyway," Catra said.

"You'd rather die with honor," Prime said, tilting his head in disappointment. "It's always the same. You people always try to

make your last stand, and for what? You can't take your dignity to your grave."

The three stood, just as determined as before, no matter how terrified they were on the inside.

"Very well," Prime said upon the lack of response. He turned to one of his soldiers. "Tell mission control to fire when ready."

"Wait." Entrapta stepped forward. She had been quiet up until now.

"What are you doing?" Catra whispered.

"You don't have to destroy anything," Entrapta walked towards Prime despite Catra and Bow's frantic looks. "You don't even need the princesses."

Prime was admittedly intrigued. He motioned for the soldier to rejoin him. "Go on."

"I have a weapon much more powerful than the heart, something that could give you control of the entire cosmos if you wanted."

"Entrapta no-" Bow tried to pull her back but she smacked his arm away.

"I could give you time."

"Time?" Prime asked.

"Yes," Entrapta nodded. "Take me instead of the princesses and leave Brightmoon alone. If you do that, I'll give you everything I know so far about traveling through time."

He still didn't look entirely convinced.

"Think about it," Entrapta went on. "You could end wars you've already fought before they've begun. Conquer civilizations before

they become civilizations. You could rewrite history in your image."

"Entrapta stop," Catra went to bring her back but the soldiers raised their weapons at her. Catra backed off.

"History you say?" Prime had a gleam in his many eyes, the gears turning in his head. "Very well. Brightmoon will be spared, for now. As for you," He stepped aside to allow Entrapta to join him. "I do hope you live up to the expectations."

Entrapta looked back at the others with a sad smile.

"You can't," Bow shook his head. "Please, don't do this."

"We can find another way," Catra said. Entrapta looked at her specifically.

"Just go with it...kitten."

Catra attempted to hide the shock on her face. All of a sudden she realized what was happening. Both sides had been played.

Turning away, Entrapta, or at least the person pretending to be her, joined Prime's side, disappearing on the ship.

Catra watched the ship ascend into the sky in utter disbelief. "Son of a-"

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The others, upon seeing Entrapta leave, rushed to Catra and Bow.

"What just happened?" Glimmer asked, having gotten there first due to teleportation. "Why did she leave with him?"

Catra waited until the others got to the clearing as well. They were just as confused and angry, making the situation worse. Catra told them all to calm down.

"How did we lose Entrapta again?" Mermista asked. "Thats, like, the second time."

"They weren't really Entrapta," Catra said.

"Double Trouble?" Glimmer frowned. "But why?"

"Because I asked them to," 6-32 said, walking out of the shadows. No one was sure how long he had been there.

"What do you mean?" Glimmer demanded.

"The real Entrapta made it extremely clear that we needed Hordak," 6-32 explained. "I wouldn't be able to get to him on my own, so I hired Double Trouble to help. They're the only one who would be willing to, or skilled enough."

"You don't get to make decisions without us," Catra said. "That wasn't your call to make."

"None of you had the will to do what was necessary," 6-32 stood by his decision. "I had to take matters into my own hands."

"And what exactly are we supposed to do now?" Mermista asked. "Prime is definitely going to notice something wrong when Double Trouble can't answer all his questions about time travel and junk."

"That's why I need to get going," 6-32 said. "Prime won't even have time to realize he's got the wrong person."

"Well I'm coming with you," Catra said.

"Yeah, us too," Bow placed a hand on Glimmer's shoulder.

"Absolutely not," 6-32 said. "You'll only slow me down."

"Too bad," Glimmer said. "You owe us. And we aren't going to take no for an answer."

6-32 groaned in frustration. "Fine. But you do everything I tell you to do." Grumbling to himself he added, "I've never seen people so

desperate to get captured in my life."

"Let's get going," Glimmer led the way to 6-32's pod. "The more time we waste arguing is just time...wasted."

"Can I expect any more inspiring speeches during the flight?" 6-32 asked mockingly.

The four left, still bickering as they faded from the rest of the rebellion's sight.

Lonnie watched with crossed arms. "You know, is it just me, or is it always only those three doing something interesting?"

The rebellion mumbled their agreement apathetically. They'd all stopped questioning it at this point.

"Hey guys," Entrapta wandered over to them, rubbing the sleep from her eyes. "Did I miss something?"

Skeletons

Chapter Summary

> *"How many times do I have to tell you people that I'm on your side?"*

Despite the fact that it was a fairly large pod, 6-32's ship definitely wasn't designed for four people, let alone the two they were supposed to be bringing back.

"When we get up there, do not leave this ship," 6-32 ordered. "You wait here unless I need you."

"Please, you'll never call us for back up," Catra said.

"Exactly," 6-32 swiveled around in his chair. "You all insisted on coming. It's not my fault that I don't need your help in the first place."

"Well we weren't just going to let you settle this yourself," Glimmer glared accusingly at him. "Do you want to tell us what other plans you've made without us knowing?"

"How many times do I have to tell you people that I'm on your side?" 6-32 asked defensively.

"We know that," Bow reassured him. "It's just, you should of told us your plan first."

"Would you have approved it?"

"No," Catra said bluntly.

"Exactly," 6-32 muttered. "Exactly my point. Why do I even bother."

The ship went around the side of the ship, landing quietly in an empty docking bay. 6-32 grabbed his gun and turned to the

others. "Stay put. Don't touch anything."

"Yes sir," Catra saluted him mockingly, to which he shuffled away, still muttering insults to himself.

"Are we really just going to wait here?" Glimmer asked, already growing impatient. She had been looking forward to a good fight.

"Well yeah," Catra shrugged. "I mean, personally, I don't want to get stuck here again. If we do get caught though, I say we sell out Bow."

"Hey!" Bow looked hurt.

"Oh relax, I'm just joking," Catra grinned deviously. "Maybe." She eyed him, claws extending.

"Hey now, watch it," Bow warned. "Don't you-"

Catra weakly clawed at him, missing by a good couple feet. Still, he stumbled backwards out of the way instinctively, losing his footing and running into the wall — which gave out from behind him.

"Woah, are you ok?" Glimmer asked, walking towards him.

Catra didn't pay him any attention though. Instead, she was looking at what Bow had uncovered.

"A secret room?" Catra asked out loud, bringing it to the others' attentions.

Sure enough, the metal wall that Bow had knocked aside was in reality a doorway which had swung open from Bow's weight. It was about the size of a large broom closet.

Catra, being the first to examine it, walked inside and felt her pulse quicken at what she saw.

The walls were lined with blueprints, more specifically, blueprints for Etheria.

"The heart..." Glimmer said, noticing them too.

Other than blueprints, there were notes scribbled on seemingly whatever 6-32 could get their hands on, except it wasn't written in any language they could read.

"That's definitely first ones writing," Bow said, tracing one particular note that he recognized. *Mara.*

Catra bent down to see a chest, full of various items. "Take a look at this."

She reached inside and pulled out a cloak, one that looked eerily like one she owned except more tattered and bloodstained. Reaching into the chest again, she pulled out more scattered notes and old bloody bandages.

"How did he get all of this?" Glimmer asked. She was examining a particularly bad drawing of Light Hope that had been pinned to the wall. "Why does he even have this stuff?"

"Guys." Catra's voice wavered.

The two turned to look at her to see her eyes focused on something at the bottom of the chest.

"What is it?" Bow was almost too scared to ask.

Catra reached in shakily, not sure if her eyes were playing tricks on her, seeing as what was at the bottom of that chest wasn't supposed to physically exist. Pulling it out into view, Glimmer and Bow felt their stomachs drop.

It was Adora's sword.

"That's not...that can’t..." Bow held his head, unable to wrap his mind around what he was seeing. "The sword was destroyed. We

have it plugged into our ship."

"How is this possible?" Glimmer asked, taking the sword from Catra who just stared at it blankly. "Is this even possible?"

The sword itself was perfectly in tact. There wasn't a fracture, or any evidence that it had been magically put back together somehow. In fact, it looked like it was brand new. No bloodstains. No cracks.

"Maybe it's a fake," Bow said. "It has to be, right?"

"Or maybe the one we have is," Glimmer countered. The stone resonated when she touched it, sending a shockwave through her body. "You can feel the power from this. It's got to be real."

"But that doesn't make sense," Bow sounded desperate. "The sword was broken. We saw that hilt plugged into the ship with our own eyes."

Glimmer looked at him sympathetically. "Obviously we missed something. Our's has to be a fake Bow, what other explanation is there?"

"I took that thing from the Crystal Castle along with Adora's dead body!" Bow yelled hysterically, voice cracking. "Don't tell me a don't know what I saw!"

"Hey, no one's doubting that," Catra said, pulling herself out of her haze to confront him. "We just need to stay calm."

"Calm?" Glimmer asked. "6-32 has been hiding this from us, maybe from the start." Stumbling back, she felt like she was going to be sick. "I can't believe I let myself get manipulated again."

"Hey," Catra snapped. "All due respect you two, but you both need to suck it up, stop feeling sorry for yourselves, and start looking for a way to fix this." Bow and Glimmer looked up at her shocked, not to say they weren't a little impressed.

"Let's just start with what we can do," Catra pushed past them out of the closet. "Either of you know how to get a signal back down there? We need to warn the others."

"I-I can try," Bow said weakly, still shaken, walking to the control panel.

"Good," Catra said before rejoining Glimmer. Catra took the sword from her hand. Addressing her quietly, she said, "We're going to figure this out, alright? We stopped 6-32 from doing whatever he was planning to do with this thing. Let's focus on that, got it?"

Glimmer nodded, leaving the closet and sitting down at the front. Catra attempted to shove the sword in her bag, though half of it was hanging out. She also threw in the cloak as an afterthought.

"We should take the pod," Glimmer said after a while. "We can't let 6-32 know that we know."

"But what about Double Trouble and Hordak?" Bow asked, looking up from his work. "We can't just leave without them."

"They'll have to be able to handle themselves," Glimmer said. "We can't let this sword fall into the wrong hands."

"She's right," Catra said. "Double Trouble can't be held prisoner for long, we all know that. And Hordak...well personally I could care less if we save him."

"Well that's not very heroic of you." A loud thud came from the ship entrance. The three turned around.

6-32 stood there, the light behind them casting their figure in shadow. He had dropped an unconscious Hordak to the ground and was standing beside a somewhat confused Double Trouble.

The three stood there, frozen as 6-32 walked ominously slow towards them. He looked behind them, seeing the open doorway and the secrets it held in plain sight.

6-32 let out a long sigh, shaking his head. "I really wish you hadn't done that."

A Wager to Die For

Chapter Summary

> Reeling from betrayal, trapped on Prime’s ship (again), a dangerous bargain may be the rebellion’s only chance at escape — but will everyone leave with their lives?

As 6-32 led the members of the rebellion through Horde Prime's ship, gun drawn and lugging Hordak on his shoulders, the three walked in silence, choking down their betrayal.

Of course he had been using us, Catra thought. She should've noticed it sooner. There was always something about him that just rubbed her the wrong way. And now? They were prisoners on Prime's ship. Again.

"You couldn't of done this before I brought Hordak to the ship," 6-32 complained. "I went through all this trouble to get him, only to bring him right back. It's annoying is what it is."

"I don't think you get a say in what's annoying," Glimmer said. "Seeing as you aren't the one in handcuffs."

"Don't take it too personally," 6-32 waved her comments aside. "It's just, well it's not like we can keep doing business as usual."

"We could've if you just told us what you were doing with the sword," Bow said. "You told us you wanted to see Prime defeated. Was that all a lie?"

"Be careful what you say on this ship," 6-32 warned.

"Why?" Catra looked back at him. "So we don't tarnish your reputation? You've only ever cared about yourself."

6-32 didn't entertain Catra's taunts, just continued guiding them to their destination.

"Well, I for one find this as deliciously intriguing as the next person," Double Trouble said, clinking their own handcuffs together. "But why couldn't I just wait in the ship Sixie?"

"Prime wanted all four of you," 6-32 said before suddenly turning his head to Double Trouble. "Wait, Sixie?"

"We had a deal," Double Trouble pouted.

"And Prime made a better one," 6-32 urged them all along. "Like I told you. It's not personal."

"He's taking us to Prime..." Glimmer whispered to Catra and Bow. "This is bad."

"You think?" Catra whispered quietly. "You barely survived the last time."

"We need to get out of here," Bow agreed. He scanned the area for escape routes but he was at a loss. The hallway they were walking down was massive with multiple corridors jutting out from the sides. With every doorway they passed, he just saw more Horde soldiers.

Looking back at 6-32, he figured the three (four including Double Trouble if they helped), could take him out. Then again, he had taken all their weapons and left them in the ship, including his bow and the sword. On top of that, even if they did overpower 6-32, the four of them would still be handcuffed with no idea how to disable them.

"Stop," 6-32 ordered. They stumbled to a halt, standing in front of a seemingly normal corridor.

"Out of curiosity," Catra asked, "What would you do if I just ran away?"

"I'd shoot you," 6-32 said deadpanned.

Catra made an act of seriously contemplating it, prompting 6-32 to nudge her forward into the room first. She reluctantly kept walking, deciding she didn't really want to test how serious 6-32 had been.

The four entered the room, which was for the most part empty and bathed in white light. At the front of it stood Horde Prime, flanked by eight guards at either side. 6-32 straightened up more at the sight, the others unintentionally doing the same.

"Well, well, well," Horde Prime grinned. "When you said you had something for me, I didn't expect this."

"You said you wanted a super weapon," 6-32 said stiffly. "I brought you everything you need for it. A scientist, a power source, and someone who's traveled through time before." He motioned to Bow, Glimmer, and Catra respectively.

"And the other?" Prime asked about Double Trouble.

"A useful mercenary, for the right price," They bowed extravagantly.

Prime walked to them, circling the group before stopping in front of 6-32.

"You worried me greatly," Prime said, his tone reminiscent of a cat playing with a mouse. "When I found out that you had been running with this planet's primitives, I thought you had lost your way." He placed a hand on 6-32's helmet, making the soldier tense. "Alas, your efforts have paid off indeed."

"Anything for the empire," 6-32 asserted.

"You coward!" Glimmer couldn't help it. She turned on him. "You're a coward! You sold us out to save your own skin!"

6-32 let her shout, didn't move against her. Prime, however, growled at the disturbance.

"So abrasive," He commented. "So...irritating. One begins to wonder if it's worth keeping them around."

"But-" 6-32 started but caught himself. "With all due respect, don't we need them?"

"We?" Prime raised an eyebrow. "We don't need anything. But, maybe you do. Tell me," Prime took the gun from 6-32's hilt and pointed it lazily at the group, "You haven't grown attached to these people, have you?"

"No," 6-32 said though he didn't sound as confident as the others expected.

"You see," Prime laughed, "I was going to make you shoot them all, as a punishment for your insolence. But, I must admit, your friend did make that new portal sound exciting. I suppose, we don't have to kill all of them do we? Maybe, just one will do. Don't you agree?"

6-32 turned to the others, nodding meekly. Catra couldn't for the life of her place the change in attitude. He had been so quick to turn on them in the ship. Why would he have second thoughts now?

Prime tossed aside 6-32's gun and pulled out one of his own, a more old-fashioned looking model that ran on bullets. He opened the gun's revolver. "Five slots. One bullet."

"I don't understand," 6-32 shook his head.

Prime reassembled the gun, spun the revolver, and put it in 6-32's hands. "I want to have a little gamble. You know I'm a sucker for a good bet."

He walked behind 6-32, looking at the four prisoners who watched with unease. "I want you to shoot each one. Whichever ones are left, I'll keep. If, by some miracle, they all survive...I'll let everyone go. How's that?"

"Do we get a say in that?" Glimmer asked, earning a elbow to the side from Catra. "Do you seriously expect us to just stand here and-"

"They'd be happy to take your wager," 6-32 intervened. There wasn't any point in arguing anyways. It was this, or they all died.

Prime motioned for 6-32 to go along. He stood there for a long moment, studying the four in front of him. Double Trouble, Bow, Glimmer and Catra stood side by side. Guards flanked each, making sure they wouldn't dodge.

6-32 raised the gun at Double Trouble's head. The latter shut their eyes, braced for the worst.

Click.

"Oh thank the heavens," Double Trouble let out a breath.

"Next," Prime urged.

Bow was next in line. He wanted to put on a brave face truthfully, but all he could think of was his fathers. He didn't want it to be him, didn't want his fathers to go through that pain. After all, if he died, his dad would kill him.

Click.

Prime's smile had widened. 6-32 was slow to raise his weapon at Glimmer.

Glimmer's heart was beating out of her chest. She regretted ever letting 6-32 into Brightmoon. She didn't want to die, not with so many unanswered question, with so much unfinished business.

Click.

Everyone looked to Catra. There was a fifty-fifty chance now. To everyone's surprise, however, she didn't look scared. She simply stared right at 6-32, unwavering. Maybe it was because she

wasn't afraid to die, or maybe it was because a part buried deep inside her still felt she might deserve it. Either way, she figured this wasn't the worst way to go out. No, she wasn't going down swinging like she'd always imagined, but at least she was surrounded by friends.

6-32's hands were steady. He didn't betray any nerves. And yet, he found that he couldn't pull the trigger though he tried.

Prime lent down to 6-32's level, whispering dangerously close. "Do it."

Bang.

The others all jumped backwards at the sound as Catra fell to the ground. 6-32 dropped the gun from his hand, watching his victim in baited breath.

Catra had never felt her heart beat so fast and as she pushed herself to a sitting position, the only thing on her mind was *how am I not dead?*

She reached for her forehead, where she was sure the bullet hit, only to find a small cut instead of a hole in her head. It took her a moment to realize that her hand had touched skin, and not the metal mask she usually wore, which was lying on the ground at her feet, the bullet lodged halfway through the metal.

"That's not possible!" Prime snarled. He grabbed 6-32 by the neck, lifting him into the air. 6-32 flailed wildly, trying to tear Prime's hand away in panic. He couldn't breathe.

"Now's our time to go," Glimmer said, still shaken. She reached out for Catra, helping her up.

"No, wait," Catra said as she got to her feet. She shouted at Horde Prime, "Wait!"

"What?" He looked to her, fury in his eyes.

"You said if we all survive, we all get to go," Catra knew she was pushing her luck. "That includes him."

"What are you doing?" Bow asked.

"We really should be going," Double Trouble said, shapeshifting to get out of their cuffs before making their way to the exit.

"I'm not leaving without knowing about that sword," Catra said before addressing Prime again. "Give him to us. Now."

Prime seemed conflicted. He didn't want to go back on his words, he was too prideful for that, and Catra knew it. Finally, he released him. 6-32 fell to the ground, barely conscious.

"This isn't over," Prime promised. "I will have my weapon. Enjoy your victory while it lasts. It may be the last you ever get."

Ignoring him, Glimmer and Bow pushed 6-32 up, pushing him to the door towards Double Trouble before grabbing the unconscious Hordak and dragging him in the same direction. Catra turned to follow them when her eyes landed on the mask that had saved her life.

Kicking it aside, she joined the others. She didn't need it anymore.

Nothing But The Truth

Chapter Summary

> The rebellion discovers the real reason 6-32 came to Brightmoon.

Bow was able to fly the group back to Brightmoon, pleasantly surprised that Prime didn't shoot their ship down in the process. As they quickly descended, he glanced back at the others.

Once they had left the range of the ship, all their handcuffs fell off, which was good because now they were able to use them for 6-32. The man in question was sitting on the floor of the pod, still lightheaded, and surrounded by the members of the rebellion.

"Give me one good reason not to blast him the second my magic starts working again," Glimmer watched him like a hawk, arms crossed.

"This." Catra held up the sword. "We need to know more about this. He can't tell us anything if you sparkle him to oblivion."

"Why aren't you angry?" Glimmer asked. "He betrayed us. He shot you!"

"But did she die?" Double Trouble asked. "I don't see what the big deal is."

"Trust me, I'm mad," Catra said. "But we can't waste our time on small vendettas. Believe me, we'll make him pay for what he did but now's not the time."

"I'm right here," 6-32 groaned.

"And you'd be on that ship dead if it weren't for me," Catra smacked him on the head. "You're welcome. Now shut it."

"I didn't want to kill you if that means anything."

"It doesn't."

"We're here," Bow called out. The pod hit the ground, rocking as it slowed to a stop. Glimmer and Catra flanked 6-32, walking him to the castle.

"Funny how the turns have tabled," Catra said.

"That's not the phrase," Glimmer shook her head.

"Really?" Catra frowned. "Are you sure?"

"Can we discuss this later?" Bow whispered as they entered the meeting room. Those who had stayed behind at the castle had been waiting in there for the others to return.

"Hordak," Entrapta immediately gasped, rushing to the unconscious man in Bow's arms.

"He'll probably need medical attention," Bow said quietly, handing him off. Entrapta took him gently, excusing herself from the room. Attention, then, turned to 6-32.

"What happened?" Sea Hawk asked.

"Maybe you want to explain," Glimmer shoved 6-32 forward. He stumbled into the center of the room. Glimmer cast a spell to imprison him within a confined circle. With all eyes on him, he straightened up.

"I did what I had to do."

"Oh please!" Glimmer yelled. "You could of killed any one of us!"

"He almost did what?" Frosta had been waiting for an excuse to punch this guy, never liking him to begin with.

Bow explained the entirety of what they missed. The secret room. The gamble. The sword.

"Before you ask, no we don't know how he got the sword," Bow put a hand up to silence the instantaneous rush of questions. "He won't tell us."

Catra took out the sword, placing it on the table. 6-32 took in a breath at the sight, not taking his eyes off of it.

"You want to tell us what you were planning to do with this?" Catra asked. "What you were willing to shoot me for?"

"Like I've said over and over again," 6-32 explained. "I didn't intend to hurt anyone. Prime forced my hand."

"After you sold us out," Glimmer interjected. "Don't forget about that part."

"Prime found out what I was doing here. If I didn't offer him something, he would have killed the entire rebellion to spite me."

"So that's suppose to justify you shooting those four in the face? Killing just one of us is fine now?" Lonnie asked.

"Yeah, it's all of us or no one at all," Perfuma said adamantly. "If you were that worried, we could of tried to fix this together."

"That was never an option," Catra said, thinking more out loud than contributing to the conversation. "You were only ever helping yourself. You kept us close because it kept you alive. That's what you told me, right? Maybe you thought that because you knew what to look for."

"Don't throw my own words back at me," 6-32 clenched his fists. "You don't know anything."

"You traded our lives for yours," Glimmer said. "That tells us everything we need to know about you. You know, a real member of this rebellion would've put their life on the line in a heartbeat, would've sacrificed-"

"Don't talk to me about sacrifice!" 6-32 pounded against the magic barrier. He dropped to his knees, overwhelmed. Everyone looked at one another, unsure of how to react.

Catra walked to the barrier, kneeling in front of him. "What could you possibly know about sacrifice?"

6-32 was breathing heavily. He didn't answer at first, lost in his own thoughts.

Glimmer appeared by Catra's side and moved her hands through the air, creating a glowing circle: a truth spell.

"How did you get the sword?"

"I told you already when this all started," 6-32's body drooped, his words weak. "I've watched people mess with time before. The sword in front of you and the broken hilt you have in your ship are the same, a single sword that's traveled through time. It just...hasn't been broken yet."

"Why are you really here?" Glimmer pressed.

6-32 looked up at her. "To make sure you don't change the past. To make sure that everything that has happened, will happen."

"And Adora?" Catra asked. "You don't think we can save her?"

"I think you'll try," 6-32 answered. "But it won't matter in the end. Nothing will change. That sword will still shatter into She-Ra's stomach." He turned to Bow. "You will still carry a dying friend in your arms." He then turned to Glimmer. "You will still put your trust in me." Finally he turned to Catra. "And you will still attend that funeral. You'll still come up with this idea, and each and every time you'll change nothing. If it takes shooting you to make sure of that, then I would do it again because time is fixed. It has to be. All that matters is making sure the past remains the past."

Glimmer dissolved the truth spell. She had heard enough. To everyone's surprise, she also got rid of the magical prison.

"Is that a good idea?" Scorpia asked but Glimmer ignored her.

"I don't want to ever see you here again," Glimmer said coldly to the guard. "You helped us a lot before and I'd like to pretend that meant something. Get out of here and understand if we ever see you again, we won't hesitate to attack."

6-32 swallowed. He was well aware of the power that surrounded him, of the glares he was receiving around the room. Slowly, he allowed himself to be led out of the castle by the guards Glimmer had called. As the doors shut behind him, he already knew he'd be seeing them all again, sooner than they'd realize and yet, to him, it would feel like a lifetime away.

The Portal

Chapter Summary

It’s time.

Entrapta sat at Hordak's side in the lab, unaware of the events transpiring two floors above her. Instead she waited patiently for her old lab partner to wake up.

She had noticed almost immediately that Prime had retrofitted Hordak with new armor, one that would support his body but blended in with the other Horde soldiers the rebellion had encountered. It piqued her interest and she made a mental note to ask 6-32 if she could study his armor to compare once she got the chance.

Still, as fascinating as the armor was, she couldn't shake the bad feelings she felt. Hordak should have woken up by now. His vitals were fine and yet for the first time Entrapta was doubting her data. If he was fine, then why did she get the feeling that something was very wrong here.

Glancing at the nearly-finished portal, she knew she was just missing one or two things. The sooner Hordak woke up, the sooner he could help her and get the machine fully functioning. That being the case, she really did need him to wake up now.

Looking around, her eyes landed on two jumper cables. Wandering over to them, she wondered if she could quicken the process.

"Theoretically, this shouldn't be able to kill him," Entrapta reassured herself. "I'm just going to give him a teeny-tiny shock." Placing them onto two plates of armor, Entrapta pressed a button sending a controlled wave of electricity into Hordak's body.

The clone immediately shot up, eyes wide open. They were green, unlike the red Entrapta was used to. He turned to her, ripping the

cables off of his body.

"How dare you attack a disciple of Horde Prime?" He demanded. When his eyes landed on Entrapta's face, however, he faltered.

"Hordak!" Entrapta smiled. "It's me!"

"My name..." Hordak shook his head as though violently trying to get rid of the negative thoughts. "I do not have a name. Do not call me that."

"Of course you have a name," Entrapta said, rushing to her tool box. His eyes followed her.

"I shouldn't be here," Hordak stood up. "Why has my fellow brother taken me from my post? Where am I?"

"You're in Brightmoon of course," Entrapta dug through her box, throwing out tools at random. "Now where is it?"

"Brightmoon..." Images of past memories came back to him. The rebellion. The Horde. Entrapta. *No*, he thought, *that was not me.*

"Aha!" Entrapta declared, holding something up triumphantly. She went to Hordak, placing the item in his hands. "I know it doesn't really fit anymore, but if you let me do some modifications I think I could improve your current body armor tenfold."

Hordak stared at the small piece of first ones tech in his hands. He recognized this, had worn it before. Looking up at Entrapta, he remembered everything. "I shouldn't be here. My former self...it was a discredit to Prime, an imperfect blot upon his reign."

"It's like I said before," Entrapta tilted her head, "Imperfection is beautiful."

Hordak looked back down at the tech and squeezed it in his hands.

"Oh we have so much to talk about," Entrapta was bouncing around the room. "Like beast island and space!"

Hordak was watching her when he noticed the machine behind her, undoubtedly a portal of some sort. "What have you been working on?"

"That?" Entrapta turned around before her eyes widened. "That! I'm supposed to ask you about that." She sat down on the workbench Hordak had originally been laying on, patting the space beside her for Hordak to join. "I need your help. How much do you know about time travel?"

•••••

Catra sat in Glimmer's windowsill, quietly contemplating the recent events. Her hand subconsciously touched the scar on her forehead as she found her mind replaying how she got it. She doubted she could ever get the image in 6-32 pointing that gun at her out of her head.

"I know you don't approve of my decision," Glimmer argued with Bow.

"I just think you should've consulted the rest of us before you let the double-crossing Horde Prime clone loose," Bow muttered.

Catra's tail flicked anxiously as she thought about 6-32. He was still a threat but at least he had done one good thing for the rebellion, even if it's something Catra really didn't like.

"What we should be worried about is Hordak," Catra said, silencing Bow and Glimmer's bickering. "Do you really think he'll be able to help Entrapta finish the portal?"

"I hope so," Bow said. "I mean, he has to, right? Otherwise, what else are we going to do?"

Catra brought her knees up to her chest, resting her head on her elbows. She didn't want to think about it.

"I'm sure they'll have the portal ready any minute now," Glimmer said. "We'll have Adora back in no time."

Catra thought that would make her feel better but oddly enough it made her feel worse. Glimmer must have noticed because all of a sudden she felt a hand squeeze her shoulder.

"Is everything alright?" Glimmer asked softly.

"It's nothing important," Catra shrugged the hand off, jumping off the window sill and sitting on one of Glimmer's stools away from the two.

"Sounds pretty important to me," Bow said. After receiving a dirty look from Catra, he added nervously, "I mean, in my opinion."

"You know you can talk to us, right?" Glimmer joined Bow again, the two looking at Catra like concerned parents trying to figure out their angsty teenager.

Catra let out a long annoyed sigh before relenting. "Fine. It's just," Catra hugged herself, "Once we get Adora back, how do I know she'll even want to see me? What if she wants nothing to do with me?"

"That doesn't sound like the Adora I know," Glimmer frowned.

"Yeah," Bow said. "Adora will see how much you've changed. She'll forgive you."

Maybe I want more than that, Catra thought fleetingly before feeling her face go red. "It's whatever. Like I said before, not important."

Glimmer had a sense of what was going on but didn't want to embarrass Catra further. Instead she had a better idea. "I know what will cheer you up. Want to go raid the kitchen for cake?"

Catra tried to seem uninterested, but her ears perking up were a dead giveaway. The three left, joking along the way. Catra found

herself smiling a little more than before. If she had made amends with these people, maybe there was hope for her and Adora after all.

•••••

Luckily for the three friends, there was plenty of cake waiting for them in the kitchen (although the cooks truthfully only made them for this exact reason). Glimmer and Catra were busy throwing chunks of frosting into each other's hair, while Bow sat off to the side, cake in one hand and recording device in the other.

"What's that for?" Catra teased. "More of your nerd notes?"

"6-32 got me thinking," Bow said, shoveling cake in his mouth in between sentences. "He's so confident we can't change the past."

"Yeah well in case you haven't noticed," Glimmer dodged a blob of blue icing and threw her own sugary handful at Catra, hitting her square in the nose, "6-32 is, like, terrible."

"I know that," Bow said, "But let's say he's right. Let's say we don't change anything." The two looked at him, neither wanting to contemplate that idea. "Maybe we don't change anything because we don't know how to. Maybe we've done all this before."

"Like a time loop?" Glimmer frowned, her momentary distraction giving Catra the perfect opportunity to slam a fistful of frosting into her face.

"Exactly." Bow nearly grabbed for another chunk of cake but seeing the destroyed plate in front of him, he decided against it. "This whole time I've been uploading my recorder with daily updates on everything that's happened since the Heart of Etheria. If something goes wrong, we can leave it for our past selves to find and then they can try to do something different."

"Wouldn't that mess up the time space continuum or whatever?" Catra asked, looking as serious as she could coated in cake.

"Paradox is the word you're looking for," Bow said. "And, yeah, I guess it would. But then again, just bringing back Adora would be a huge paradox by itself. Like how would we know to go back in time to save her if she never died in the first place? Unless..." He trailed off, deep in thought.

"You're breaking my brain," Glimmer groaned. She had a headache, both from getting repeatedly hit in the face with cake and from the sugar rush. "Can we please not talk about paradoxes right now?"

"Paradoxes? I love paradoxes!" Entrapta came running into the kitchen.

"We don't have time for this," Catra complained, knowing full well that Entrapta could ramble about paradoxes for hours.

"We're literally not doing anything right now," Glimmer pointed out before walking to Entrapta. She wiped the cake from her face, although she missed a spot on her cheek where the bright blue shimmered in the fluorescent kitchen lighting. "Did you need anything?"

"Yes!" Entrapta said. "Hordak and I were able to stabilize the portal. We think it can be fully functional in a few hours."

The three shared a look. They had spent so long working towards this moment, and yet none of them really thought it would come. The portal was ready. They were going to see Adora again.

"We'll meet you in the war room," Bow said, already contacting the rest of the rebellion on his holopad. Entrapta nodded, leaving the room, commenting on how they should make little cakes later to celebrate.

Catra watched her leave, unsure of how to feel. That doubt crept back up again.

"Hey," Glimmer elbowed her. "Relax. This'll work."

It has to, Catra thought.

•••••

The rebellion took their time discussing what they should do. As Entrapta explained it, she could transport all of them from one time to another using the portable bracelets she had designed. In theory, they would allow so that the princesses wouldn't actually need to go through the portal to travel back to their own time, just be within range of it. Of course, it's only 'in theory' because nobody actually knows if they'll work or not. Despite Entrapta's reassurances that they shouldn't be torn between realities, the rebellion wasn't too confident.

Everyone would go, but only a small team would actually go for Adora. The rest would stay behind as back up, both to protect Entrapta and Hordak who would need to keep the portal going and to ensure that nobody's past selves saw what they were doing.

"We must be very careful to change as little as possible," Entrapta explained. "The more we change, the more we can effect the future, which is right now for us."

"And how exactly are we suppose to do that if we're bringing Adora dearest back from the dead?" Double Trouble asked. "Sounds like a major change to me."

"Glad you asked," Bow said. "Because that's actually where we're going to need your expertise."

"You have my interest," Double Trouble leaned forward in their chair.

"Here's what I was thinking," Bow explained. He brought out his little figurines for demonstration purposes. "Me, Glimmer, Catra and Double Trouble find Adora. We help her disable the Heart of Etheria without her dying. Soon after that, past me is suppose to show up to find Adora's body, except this time it won't be Adora. It'll be you." He pointed to Double Trouble who's eyes lit up.

"You want me to play the fallen hero?" They smiled deviously. "I promise, it'll be my best performance yet."

"It's certainly an act we'll remember," Bow said quietly.

"So if Bow still finds fake-Adora then what happens to real-Adora?" Frosta asked.

"I have another bracelet!" Entrapta said, pulling it out into view. "We'll take her forward with us to our time."

The others were beginning to like this plan. Double Trouble ensured that they'd be able to get their heart rate low enough to play dead and Bow explained that after her initial death, nobody ever really saw her body after he dropped it off in the castle morgue. They had thought through seemingly everything.

"What about this?" Catra asked, drawing everyone's attention to her. She was holding the sword.

"We bring it back with us," Glimmer said. "I think...I think it's the sword She-Ra is supposed to shatter."

An unsettling hush fell over the room. If that were the case, then Catra was holding a murder weapon.

"Let's hope it doesn't have to come to that," Bow said, trying to keep the mood light. "Entrapta? Anything else you'd like to add?"

"Hm," She thought for a moment. "Everyone just try their best not to be seen by their past selves. We don't really know how we'd react to seeing our doubles-" A couple glanced to Double Trouble who just shrugged "-so we have to assume they'd attack. As for Adora...let's hope she doesn't try to kill you four." She directed that last part to the ground team who nodded bleakly.

The meeting was called to a close and everyone gathered their last few things before they met up at the portal.

"How are you going to hide that thing?" Glimmer asked Catra, eyeing the sword. Catra strapped it to her back and then threw her cloak over it.

"Can you see it?" Catra asked, spinning around to let Glimmer check. "I don't want some princess attacking me because they think I stole it."

"Technically we did steal it," Glimmer mumbled.

"From someone who stole it before us," Catra glared.

They entered the portal room, the machine vibrating as it was powering up. Catra examined the bracelet on her wrist. It didn't look that fancy, just a silver band with a few glowing engravings, but it was the key that was about to send her hurtling through time. She tried not to look at the portal too much, just hoping this would be a positive experience instead of like the last time.

"I can only keep this portal on for about an hour," Entrapta explained, "Maybe a little more before it becomes too dangerous. We need to get this all done fast. The instability of this operation means we only have one shot at this if we don't want to completely rupture the already fragile flow of time."

"Then let's make this count," Glimmer said. She turned to Entrapta. "Ready?"

"Oh this is going to be so exciting!" Entrapta laughed as she flipped a few switches. "Going back in time in five...four...three...two..." She slammed a button and the room was overwhelmed with bright light.

Catra felt a sensation she was all too familiar with. As the portal sent them away, it felt as though her entire body was dissolving and reforming itself all at once.

When the light died down, and she could feel solid earth beneath her feet, Catra looked around to see they were standing in the same place they were before: Brightmoon's lab.

"Did it work?" Scorpia asked. "Nothings different."

"Guys," Bow said, looking out the window. "I think it definitely worked."

They all rushed to the window as well to see magic flowing up out of the earth.

"The Heart," Glimmer whispered.

"We need to get moving," Catra said, already heading out the door. "If it's been activated, then that means Adora's already on her way to the Crystal Castle."

"Right," Glimmer said, getting a grip on herself. "Ground team, let's go. Everyone else-"

"We've got it covered," Mermista reassured her. "Now go."

"And make it quick!" Entrapta shouted.

With that settled, Glimmer, Bow, Double Trouble and Catra left the safety of Brightmoon, running through the forest in the direction of the castle.

"Hey, how come the weapon isn't affecting you Sparkles?" Catra asked. "Shouldn't it be draining you?"

"Maybe it recognizes I'm not from here?" Glimmer threw the idea out unsurely.

"Let's just be grateful darlings," Double Trouble called out. "You really don't have to question everything."

"Let's slow down," Bow said, holding out a hand for them to stop running. "We should be far enough ahead by now."

"We shouldn't waste our time waiting," Glimmer argued. "Let's just get to the Castle before anyone else. Maybe we can destroy it without Adora even getting involved."

The two kept arguing. Catra was about to offer her input when her ear twitched. She could hear the sounds of branches snapping and heavy breathing. Someone was coming toward them, and fast.

"Guys, shut up," Catra told them, ducking behind the bushes alongside the path. The other three did the same.

The person in question came into view, close to where they were, stopping as her form began to glow. The girl cursed, looking into the distance with an expression of anger and fear.

Everyone stared, not sure what to do. They knew this moment was coming and yet? No one was prepared to see She-Ra again.

Catra stood up.

"Wait, what are you-" Glimmer went to drag her back down but Catra stepped out onto the path.

The girl turned around, glaring at Catra. *It doesn't matter if she's angry*, Catra thought. *It just matters that she believes me.*

Catra smiled sadly, saying the only thing that could come to mind.

"Hey Adora."

Adora

Chapter Summary

"Promise you won't leave me again. Promise you'll stay."

Catra and Adora stood facing one another, Adora with her sword aimed at the ready.

"I don't have time for this right now," Adora said coldly. "Get out of my way Catra."

Catra didn't move. She couldn't take her eyes away from Adora. There was so much fight in her, so much hatred in her eyes. How was she supposed to make this right?

"Whatever," Adora shook her head, pushing past the girl. Despite her curiosity, she really didn't have time to ask why Catra wasn't at the Horde. "You should get out of here. It's not safe."

"Adora wait," Catra grabbed Adora's arm, pulling her back. Adora turned to her, pulling her hand away harshly. She faltered when she saw Catra's expression. Why did she look so different? She only just now noticed the sadness in her eyes, the missing Force Captain pin, the new scar on her forehead clearly visible without her usual mask.

"Adora," Catra pleaded. "Don't go to that castle."

Adora looked at the building in the distance, at the streams of energy erupting from the ground. "I have to stop Light Hope."

"You'll die trying," Catra's voice wavered.

"Is that a threat?" Adora's eyes narrowed.

"No," Another voice came from the bushes. "It's the future."

Adora turned to see Bow walking towards her, followed by Glimmer and Double Trouble. *Shouldn't they be at the Horde too?* Adora thought.

"What's going on?" Adora asked. She turned to Catra. "Why are you with them?"

"I know it's crazy," Catra said, "But we don't have a lot of time to explain everything. We're from the future, Adora. We're here to save you."

Adora laughed, looking to the others expecting to see them responding the same way but their serious faces left her even more confused. "You...you really expect me to believe that?"

"She's telling the truth," Glimmer said. "We're trying to help you."

"Help me?" Adora glared. "Well maybe you shouldn't of set off the alien super weapon in the planet. Did it ever occur to you to maybe stop that from happening instead?"

"Believe me when I say I'll pay for that decision," Glimmer said. "But you shouldn't have to."

Adora looked to Bow, feeling as though he was the only one she could even talk to right then. The way he looked at her though seemed to be confirmation of everything on its own. Still not understanding completely, not knowing how it was even possible, Adora realized at the very least they believed what they were saying.

"So the future," Adora finally said. "I'm not in it?"

"That's what we're trying to change," Bow said. "Because otherwise, you'll die sacrificing yourself in the Crystal Castle. A-And I don't think I can watch that happen again."

"Again..." Adora looked down at the sword. Truthfully, there was a part of her that always assumed she'd die in this war. Mara had. It's not that she wasn't willing to make the sacrifice but it's not

like she was in a rush to see that happen. Now she was being told that death was on her doorstep. Her friends, people who had never worked together before as far as she knew, had traveled through time to stop it from happening.

"I'm sorry," Adora took a deep breath. "But I have to stop Light Hope. Even if it ends the way you say it will. You can't stop me from going to the castle."

"Then don't go alone," Catra placed a hand on Adora's, "I can't lose you again. So no matter what happens, I'm not leaving you."

Adora felt her face heat up. She had never seen Catra so vulnerable. "Alright," She said softly, trying not to wonder if this was one of the last moments she would have with her old friend. There were so many things she wanted to know, so much she had apparently missed. It wasn't clear if she'd ever get those answers, but she had to hope.

Leading the way, Adora took the four to the Crystal Castle. "Here's the plan," She explained. "I'll keep Light Hope busy and buy you all some time. You four get to her core processing unit and try to shut her off. There will be a crystal that you need to destroy. If we can disable her, maybe we can stop the weapon."

"I'll keep watch," Double Trouble said. "I'm not much of a fighter after all. This way if any unwanted visitors come by, I can lead them in the wrong direction."

"Fine," Glimmer said. "But make sure you're here when we need you."

"Why exactly do we need them?" Adora asked. Up until that point she really hadn't understood why they were there in the first place.

"We needed them to be you." Bow explained how their past selves needed to believe Adora died. Adora understood, though she wasn't thrilled with the idea.

"One more thing," Catra said, reaching behind her. "You're going to need this."

Adora felt like her brain was going to break in two when Catra took out the sword. Looking down at her own, she wasn't sure what to make of it.

"How..." She took Catra's sword, feeling the same power radiating off of it, except it was older and had a stronger pull.

"We don't know why," Catra admitted, "But we think that's the sword you're meant to take in there."

Adora decided to give her original sword to Catra. "Use this one then."

Catra took it, shocked that Adora would trust her with it. They didn't have time to dwell on it though, and headed into the castle.

Light Hope was standing at the front of the room, focused on the Heart of Etheria controls in front of her. Turning around to face Adora, she reached out a hand.

"I am glad you are here," Light Hope said. "Now we can begin."

"You won't do anything to her!" Glimmer shouted, sending a shockwave of magic at the woman. Light Hope wavered, irked by the minor annoyance.

"My sensors tell me that you three should not be here," Light Hope frowned. She was detecting two energy signatures from Glimmer, one in the castle and one in the Fright Zone. That shouldn't be possible. There were also two swords, complicating things further. She recognized that the one in Adora's hands was older than Catra's, and therefore much stronger. She would need to channel the weapon through that one.

"Did you really think we'd let Adora do this alone?" Catra growled. She knew she couldn't hurt the hologram itself, but her eyes were already scanning for the processing unit.

"Over there!" Adora shouted. The others followed her gaze and saw what they were looking for. "Go!"

Light Hope raised her hand, creating an army of spiders. Glimmer and Bow charged forward, fighting their way through the creatures. Catra, however, fell back, protecting Adora.

"What are you doing?" Adora asked her.

"I told you already," Catra grinned back at her. "Whatever happens."

"Whatever happens," Adora echoed, a warm feeling washing over her. She turned back to Light Hope, prepared for the worst.

"Your weapon is useless," Adora shouted over the fighting. "You can't reach anyone in the empty dimension."

"With the connection between the runestones restored, portal capabilities are back online," Light Hope brought up more controls. "Preparing the jump out of Despondos."

"You had to give her that idea?" Catra complained, slicing at spiders with her new weapon. Did she feel weird using She-Ra's sword? Oh yeah, definitely. She half heartedly wondered if Adora would let her keep it when they were done.

Glimmer and Bow were almost to the panel when the castle started shaking. They could feel the planet moving through space.

"The time has come," Light Hope said. "The Heart of Etheria will be fired." Adora screamed as the power streaming into the castle was directed into her body. She fell to her knees, light pouring out of her.

"Adora!" Catra cried. A spider knocked the sword out of her hand, slashing her arm. Slicing it away with her other hand, she rushed to Adora's side.

"Y-You can't," Adora whispered. She couldn't fight this for long. "I'll hold her off. Go. Help Glimmer and Bow."

Catra looked to the other two, seeing that they were being overpowered. They weren't going to make it. Turning back to Adora, she felt her eyes brimming with tears.

"Go," Adora reassured her.

"Promise you won't leave me again," Catra begged. "Promise you'll stay."

Adora smiled, trying to ignore the tears streaming down her own face. "I promise."

Catra stood up weakly, hesitant to take her eyes away from Adora. Pulling herself together, she ran away to Glimmer and Bow's aid. She didn't know where the sword went but she figured she'd have to make do. Part of her wished she had brought another grenade.

Adora gritted her teeth, forcing herself to stand back up. She kept the sword as low to the ground as she could, bleakly aware of what would happen should she fail.

Catra slashed at the spiders on top of Bow, then Glimmer, freeing her to teleport them as close to the processing unit as possible.

"We got this," Glimmer yelled, covering Catra's back. "Go!"

Catra knelt by the unit, a large wall with a crystal sticking out of one of two slots. Gripping the crystal, Catra tugged with all her might to pull it loose.

Light Hope, who only just realized how close they were, turned her attention to Catra and the others. Adora yelled at Light Hope, desperate to continue distracting her but she could only focus on so many things at once. The sword was her main priority.

"Almost...got it," Catra grunted, feeling the crystal almost come loose completely before Light Hope blasted an electricity wave at

them. Catra shrieked as the blast hit her back, letting go of the crystal which lodged itself back into the slot before the wall slid into the ground, disappearing completely.

"No!" Bow shouted as he saw Light Hope ready another energy blast. This time, however, instead of aiming it at anyone in particular, she sent it across the room, splitting the castle in two and forming a barrier.

Catra, Glimmer and Bow were stuck on one side. Adora was alone on the other.

Remembering the memory they saw in the crystal castle, the group realized they had been in this situation before: stuck behind a force field only to watch Adora die.

It was happening again.

A Fixed Timeline

Chapter Summary

a choice made, a destiny fulfilled, a hero lost to time

Power.

Power coursed through every bone in She-Ra's body, filled the empty spaces in between her atoms, ingrained itself in every molecule.

Pure pain. Nerves on fire. Heart pounding, ready to burst like the heart of the planet and the hopes of her friends. Everything Adora had left to give was channeled into keeping the sword to the ground. She couldn't fire the weapon. She couldn't.

"You will comply." Light Hope urged her to keep going. The poor girl gripped onto the sword as every instinct in her body fought against each other. *Fire it. Stop it. Fire it. Stop it.*

Adora could feel the princesses weakening. They were connected. They were in pain, and to make matters worse, she could feel everything they could.

The worst wasn't the physical pain though. It was knowing what was about to happen and realizing that her friends couldn't change the inevitable after all.

Risking a glance, she saw them watching through the barrier, fighting off Light Hope's monsters. It seemed they'd need a miracle if they wanted to survive this themselves.

Agonizingly, Adora brought herself back to her mission, fighting to stay focused and knowing if she succumbed to the misery for even a moment...it would all be over.

With every inch she pushed the sword down, it just felt like it went higher. The magic flowing through Adora couldn't be

contained much longer. She knew deep down she couldn't keep this up forever. She hadn't before. On top of that, no one was coming. Her friends traveled through an entire timeline and they still wouldn't be able to stop what was coming. This was a fight Adora would have to face alone. At the very least, even if it was fated to happen anyways, Adora was going to make the decision on what was to come. She only hoped the others would forgive her.

"This isn't my destiny," Adora spat the words out. "I am not your weapon." She managed a look at Light Hope to see the aged hologram faltering. Regardless, both knew there was no fighting her programming, just like there was no fighting Adora's.

It hit her in that moment harder than before. Adora didn't want to die. Even though she knew it was coming, she was still scared. She wondered if Mara had felt the same way.

"Mara knew you were more than this," Adora pleaded in a last ditch effort, not ready to let go just yet. If she could just gain herself a little more time, get Light Hope to loosen for just one moment, maybe the others could break through the barrier. There was no time though. Adora knew if she didn't do something now, she'd destroy the planet.

Her words at least did something. Light Hope was glitching, caught between two different selves. Adora could feel the conflict waging inside her as the sword lifted even higher than before.

Light Hope seemed to make up her mind.

"Do it."

Oddly enough, this part didn't take as much effort as she thought, or maybe it just seemed that way. In the brief moment before the sword hit the ground, Adora felt something she hadn't known for a long time: clarity. This moment was the moment she knew had been coming from the start, the moment she'd dreaded, and yet, in that moment...everything fell into place.

Braced for the inevitable, Adora used what was left of her strength to plunge the sword downwards. Shattering, Adora sucked in a breath as the shrapnel lodged itself into her torso.

The Crystal Castle was reduced to rubble before her very eyes. Adora barely made out the image of Light Hope standing above her, thanking her, before the woman disappeared. The whole cavern seemed to erase itself from existence. She couldn't see the others. As she was left standing there, she looked around. She was alone and bleeding in a void of nothing.

Coughing, Adora was lying on the floor now. She didn't remember getting there. She could feel the metal pushing against her insides with every breath. Biting her tongue, Adora pulled a larger chunk of metal out, splattering even more blood onto the floor. Gasping in pain, she knew all too well she was only making the process go quicker but at the very least it was something she could control. Thinking of her friends, it seemed better to go quick instead of giving them hope. The thought of them blaming themselves when this went south? No, they'd be better off if they didn't try to save her. No more She-Ra meant no more pawn to be played. They could go home and forget this.

If there was any comfort to be felt, it came from the shock that was taking over, numbing the pain if only slightly.

Footsteps. Shouting. Adora rolled her head to the side to see people fast approaching. They were saying something but Adora couldn't make out what the words were. It was just noise to her.

With Light Hope gone, the barrier had dropped. Bow was the first to reach Adora, falling to his knees beside her. "No, please not again."

Catra and Glimmer joined him. Double Trouble came into view as well, staying off to the side, still acting as a look out.

"Did we do it?" Adora asked, voice trembling. She couldn't focus very easily, so she just looked at Catra.

"We did it," Catra reassured her, squeezing the girl's hand.

Adora smiled. Sinking back down, she breathed as steadily as she could. Bow and Glimmer held onto one another, sobbing as they watched. Catra looked at the two, then Adora, then stood up in anger.

"We aren't just giving up," Catra swallowed down her own grief. "We didn't come all this way for it to end like this."

"Catra..." Adora started but Catra cut her off.

"You don't get to argue," Catra choked out. Taking off her cloak, she wrapped it around Adora's waist to help stop the bleeding before turning to Bow. "Grab her. We're bringing her back to Brightmoon."

Bow, not having the energy to fight back, did as he was told. Holding her in his arms again only served as a reminder of what he'd already lost. He didn't want to go through that again.

"Double Trouble, you know what to do?" Catra asked.

Smiling, Double Trouble shifted into Adora, injury and all. "The show must go on." Lying down where Adora had been previously, they made sure to cover their lower half with the blood, making it as realistic as possible for when the past-Bow would show up.

"Glimmer," Catra grabbed onto her and Bow's hands. "Get us out of here."

Glimmer nodded determinedly. Still not at full strength, she knew she wouldn't be able to get them at Brightmoon castle's doorstep, but they'd be close enough.

As she teleported away, the others could hear another pair of footsteps approaching. It had to be this timeline's Bow. Gone, unable to see what happened next, they all just had to hope that they had set everything in motion. At the very least, their timeline

wouldn't change — but it would all be worthless if Adora didn't pull through.

The group materialized about a mile away from the castle. They'd have to run from there, but they had a clean shot.

"Stars..." Adora mumbled, looking up to the sky. "I missed seeing...the stars..."

"You'll get to see them plenty," Glimmer told her, "Just hold on."

They tried not to take into account how pale Adora had become. Her breathing rattled her body, each breath more labored than the last.

"You don't get to die on me like this," Catra said to her. "Alright? We're getting you to that castle. You're going to be fine." Adora tried to look at her but couldn't make her out in the fast moving surroundings, and settled on just closing her eyes for the time being.

"Hey, no, stay awake," Bow said, speeding up as the castle came into view. "Just stay awake."

Adora truly was trying, but it wasn't good enough. She just wanted to rest. There was so much blood. Why did her chest hurt again? She'd forgotten.

Once at the castle, the group didn't care who saw them but luckily the floors they went past were all empty (strange seeing as they should've been guarded but they assumed the princesses had something to do with that). Bursting into the lab, those who stayed behind immediately jumped to their feet when they saw Adora in Bow's arms.

"Oh god," Micah said. He swiped everything off one of Entrapta's tables, instructing Bow to set her down. Entrapta came over immediately, Perfuma close behind with a first aid kit.

"Help me patch the wound," Bow said. He placed Adora carefully down, feeling bad as she winced when the cold metal touched her skin. Catra stood at her side, holding tightly onto Adora's hand.

They worked to wrap the wound, at the very least stopping the blood flow, but they weren't in an infirmary. They didn't have the right equipment, or a way to give Adora blood. It was looking bad.

"Stay here," Mermista said shakily, taking Scorpia and Sea Hawk with her. "We'll get help, equipment, something." They rushed off but Adora knew they wouldn't be quick enough. She could feel how little fight she had left.

"The portal only has a few minutes left," Entrapta informed everyone. "We need to be prepared for a jump."

"Somebody get Adora her bracelet," Glimmer ordered. "We can take her with us and finish saving her once we're back."

Entrapta reached into her pockets before frowning. She scrambled around, looking under machines and papers before shaking her head. "I-I don't have it."

"What do you mean you don't have it?" Perfuma asked. "How else are we suppose to bring Adora home?"

"I'm sorry," Entrapta ran to her toolbox in despair. "It's gone. B-But it's not too late! I can make a new one!" She rushed off, trying to find parts.

Adora was able to piece together what was going on. There was no going home for her. She used what was left of her energy to squeeze Catra's hand. Catra, noticing, knelt beside Adora so their faces were closer. Adora stared at Catra weakly.

"It's ok," Adora's words were so soft, Catra was the only one who could properly hear them in the chaos. "You're going to...going to be ok."

"You're such an idiot," Catra cried out. "I should be the one telling you that, not the other way around."

"It was...the only...way," Adora mustered up enough strength to squeeze Catra's hand again.

"No," Catra's shoulders shook with sobs. She buried her face in Adora's hand, cupping her face in the girl's weak grasp. "No, you don't get to do this, you don't get to-to..."

Catra felt Adora's hand go limp. She looked up to see Adora wasn't really looking at her anymore, just staring off into the middle distance. The sound of her heartbeat, which Catra had been carefully tuned into since they got there, was lost.

Mermista, Scorpia, and Sea Hawk returned with a blood-coated Double Trouble at their side, but upon seeing everyone's faces, knew they were all too late. They joined the crowd, as they formed around Adora. Even Entrapta gave up on the bracelet, only acknowledging that they had one minute before the portal would bring them back.

"Please," Catra whispered into the silent room. "Stay. You promised."

Everything was still, when a bright white light began to encompass the room. At first, the princesses thought it was the portal before they realized the light was coming from Adora and Catra. One by one, each princess and rebellion fighter began to glow as well, showering the room in color.

"What's happening?" Catra turned to the others, unsure of what to do.

All eyes turned to Adora, watching desperately to see even a sign that she was alive. Could this be healing her? Too soon though, the portal began to buzz. They had seconds.

"No, not yet!" Catra begged. She went to wrap her arms around Adora but felt her arms dissolve before she got the chance.

When she finally regained her senses, Catra blinked away the blinding light and saw nothing in front of her but an empty table.

6-32

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

No one in that room could look away from the spot that Adora had just been. They were so close. This couldn't be right.

"What happened?" Catra asked shakily. "Did it work? I-Is she safe or not?"

"I don't know," Glimmer responded numbly.

Catra got up, grabbing Glimmer by the shoulders. "You're the magic one," She shouted in her face. "You should know! What happened to Adora?"

"Calm down," Scorpia went to Catra's side, pulling her away from the princess.

"Don't tell me to calm down!" Catra shoved her away. "We should be doing something! We need to go back-"

"We can't," Entrapta shook her head. "We already ruptured the flow of time once. Returning to the same point would likely cause the stream to collapse in on itself entirely."

Catra wanted to scream at her too but couldn't. She sank down, back against the table, hugging herself closely. Scorpia sat beside her, trying her best to console her.

"Is there anything else we can do?" Glimmer asked Bow. He just shook his head, hugging her for comfort.

A knock at the door drew everyone's attention. It creaked open to reveal the general.

"I'm sorry to interrupt," She said. "But you all have a visitor."

Catra's ears perked up, tail flicking anxiously. *Could she get her hopes up?*

"Who...who is it?" Glimmer asked, hoping the same thing.

"6-32," The general said to everyone's disappointment. "He's at the grave sight and he refuses to leave without talking to everyone. Do you want us to ready an attack my Queen?"

"No," Glimmer said, her hopes replaced with bitter annoyance. "We don't know what he has up his sleeve. I'll meet him."

"I'm sorry but his instructions were quite clear," The general stopped her. "It's everyone or no one."

Glimmer looked back at the others. They were in no shape to be dealing with this but the longer 6-32 was on Brightmoon, the more dangerous he could potentially be.

The group left the room, Catra almost not following as she didn't feel quite ready to leave the table's side, felt guilty as if she was somehow leaving Adora.

Walking out to the garden, sure enough 6-32 was standing in front of Adora's grave. When he heard the group approaching he turned around.

"You're back," 6-32 sounded surprised, frozen in place.

"What are you doing here?" Glimmer growled, summoning her magic threateningly. She didn't bother wiping the tears from her eyes, though she hoped he didn't see them. The others took similar stances, too exhausted mentally and physically to fight, but ready for one nonetheless.

"It must of only been minutes," 6-32 thought out loud, coming closer.

"Don't," Catra warned. "Don't try anything. We told you before, you aren't welcome here." Truthfully she was just waiting for an

excuse to tear into him, desperate to take her anger out on someone.

6-32 stared for a moment, before he began to laugh. Not a cruel one, not a mocking or crazed one. Just pure relief, as though the weight of the world had been lifted off his shoulders. It was a laugh that almost sounded familiar.

"So what? You've come to gloat?" Glimmer scowled. "Well, we don't want to hear your 'I told you so's.' We don't need to hear your little time-is-fixed speech. We...we get it. You were right."

6-32 regained his composure, quelling his laughter. He walked forward again to the group, even though they still raised their weapons at him. He didn't mind, didn't care about that anymore.

"You should be glad you didn't change anything," 6-32 said. He reached for his mask, releasing the lock mechanism and sliding it off his face. "Otherwise, I guess I wouldn't be here."

The group faltered as they saw themselves not face to face with a Horde clone but with an old friend. She looked different than the version of her that they saw only moments ago. Her eyes were sadder, more tired, her hair cut much shorter to fit in the helmet better, and there was fresh bruising around her neck — but it was Adora.

Everyone dropped their weapons. Adora tossed aside the helmet. She wouldn't need it anymore.

"I'm sorry I couldn't tell you all sooner," Adora massaged her jaw, happy to breathe in air that wasn't filtered through Horde technology. Her voice was hoarse from the injuries. "I-I know you might be mad at me but-"

"Mad?" Glimmer rushed to her, crushing her in her arms. "How could we be mad?"

Adora hesitantly hugged back before sinking into the embrace. "To be fair, I almost got you all killed. Like. A lot."

The rest of the princesses ran to her too, dog-piling the poor girl. They were all sobbing about how much they had missed her.

"But how is this possible?" Bow finally asked once everyone pulled away. "How did you do all this?"

"Well..." Adora looked away nervously. "Let's just say I had to get really good at acting really fast. It was terrible. But-" She slid her hand into her pocket, pulling out a familiar device, "-I had some help along the way."

"My communicator," Bow's eyes widened. He reached into his own pocket to find it was missing.

"You left it," Adora smiled. "It's how I knew what to do. Although, it took me a while to figure out I was suppose to be the Horde soldier you all hated so much."

"You've been helping us this entire time, haven't you?" Glimmer thought back to the first time they met 6-32, to all the times they helped one another and fought. "You never really left. You...went to your own funeral. That's...that's extremely messed up, right?"

"That part was weird, yes," Adora didn't like thinking back to that day. "I wish you all didn't have to go through that. And I wish I hadn't done some of the things I did. Selling you out, shooting at you, getting the ship blown up-"

"You were in the ship?!" Bow shrieked in horror. "The one that exploded?!"

"It wasn't my best idea but somebody had to do it," Adora admitted sheepishly. "And, well…you guys know most of the rest."

It was hard to hear what everyone was saying, seeing as everyone was talking over one another. A lot of them still had questions. It was a lot, and even though she was happy to be reunited with everyone, there was one person Adora hadn't spoken to yet.

Catra was standing away from the group, arms crossed and back turned to the commotion. She hadn't joined in the group hug, hadn't even said a word.

The others followed Adora's gaze and quieted down, stepping aside to let her walk by. Adora stopped behind Catra, reaching out her hand at first before putting it back at her side. There were so many things she had to say.

Catra was aware that Adora was standing there but she didn't move. She kept her arms close to herself, part of her refusing to get her hopes up. She didn't deserve anything from Adora, didn't believe she should get to participate in that happiness the others felt.

"Hey Catra," Adora finally said, tired but not unfriendly.

Catra didn't respond, though her ears drooped.

Adora had imagined this moment plenty during her time undercover. She had thought up a million different ways this conversation could go. Now though, her words were getting caught in her throat. She didn't expect for tears to come to her eyes, so when her vision blurred she realized she had no idea where to begin.

"We were never very good at promises," Adora finally said, reaching for Catra's hand. "I thought it was about time I kept one. Maybe-"

Her words were cut off as Catra turned around, unable to take it anymore and launching into a hug around her old friend. Catra gripped onto Adora, afraid that she would disappear again, not wanting to ever let go. Adora melted into the embrace, wrapping her own arms around Catra.

She pulled away, to see Catra with tears in her eyes. Lovingly, she cupped Catra's face. "I told you. I'm here to stay. I'm not going anywhere."

"You better not," Catra laughed weakly, "Or I'll have to travel across space-time again to find you."

Adora found all of the thoughts that had been running through her head the past months spilling over the surface. The desperation she had felt to talk to Catra again, the loneliness she had felt behind the mask, the happiness of seeing her with the rebellion. "I'm so proud of you."

"For what?" Catra wiped away her tears. The two girls stood close together, hand in each other's hand.

"For everything," Adora said. "I always knew there was a good person in you Catra, and you didn't need me around to find that out for yourself."

Catra shook her head. "You're an idiot," She mumbled before looking back up at Adora. "Don't you get it? Everything I did...I did for you."

Say it, Catra thought to herself. *Say it now, while you still have the chance, before you lose her again.*

"Hey," Adora said softly, touching their foreheads together. "I love you too."

Catra closed the gap, lips meeting Adora's, both of them feeling truly happy for the first time in a long while. They ignored the coos of their friends behind them, didn't think about the war that would still be waging tomorrow, tuned out the entire world for that one moment.

Whatever the universe would throw at them next, whatever Prime was planning, none of it mattered. They could finally be themselves again. They wouldn't be leaving one another any time soon. Together, they both knew that nothing could stop them, not even death.

When they pulled away, both were red in the face, smiling despite themselves.

"Do you know how long I've wanted to do that?" Catra asked.

"Does this mean you'll finally admit that you missed me?" Adora smiled mischievously.

"Not a chance," Catra wrapped her tail around the two. "Now come on, let's get you out of that armor. It reeks."

Adora rolled her eyes but followed anyways. For the first time in ages, she didn't know what was supposed to happen next but she was ok with that.

Adora would have time to figure it out.

Chapter End Notes

Hello!

Hope y'all enjoyed this wild ride and guess what, it's not over! I already have planned out a sequel from Adora's point of view. Fair warning though, I'm trying to finish up some other projects first (nudge, nudge, shameless self-promotion) so it might be a while before you see that.

A little preview nonetheless:

Grappling with the past.

Burdened by the future.

When we put on our masks, who do we become?

Find out in *6-32's Guide to Destroying the World.*

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!